Inheritance of fields of study

Adam Altmejd[a]

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Abstract

Children of university graduates are twice as likely to earn a degree in their parent's field. I link Swedish university applicants from 1977–1992 to their children's later outcomes and exploit admission thresholds in a fuzzy regression discontinuity design. When a parent earns a degree in a broad field, the probability that the child later graduates from that field rises by 4.6 percentage points (46%). Parental STEM enrollment raises children's math scores by 0.18 standard deviations, but children who follow a parent earn about 30% lower returns to their field choice. Transmission is especially strong when parents choose gender-atypical fields.

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Institute for Evaluation of Labour Market and Education Policy. adam.altmejd@ifau.uu.se.

1 Introduction

To what extent do parents determine the career trajectories of their children? Education and occupation choices remain strongly persistent across generations, even when barriers to schooling are relatively low (Björklund and Salvanes 2011; Black and Devereux 2011; Blanden et al. 2023). Much of this persistence may arise long before labor market entry, through educational specialization. Because fields of study channel graduates into distinct occupational tracks, parents' field choices may shape which academic options their children consider and, ultimately, which occupations they enter. Descriptively, children are much more likely to earn a degree in the same field as their parents (Andrade and Thomsen 2017; Van de Werfhorst et al. 2001). But these raw associations do not identify causal parental influence, because families share resources, social networks, genetic endowments, and preferences that shape the educational choices of both generations.

Even with credible causal estimates, interpreting the underlying mechanisms presents a second major challenge. If parents primarily transmit field-specific skills (Hanushek et al. 2023; Hvide and Oyer 2018), intergenerational spillovers may reflect efficient matching. But persistence can also arise without productivity gains. If inheritance operates through privileged access (Kramarz and Skans 2014; Staiger 2023), it may instead worsen talent misallocation (Almgren et al. 2025). Similar distortions may arise if parents act as role models, provide information about different fields, or make some options seem more accessible. Distinguishing between these channels is crucial for understanding whether field inheritance raises productivity or reinforces inequality.

To answer this question, I link population-wide administrative data on Swedish university applicants from 1977–1992 to the later educational and labor market outcomes of their children, observed through 2023. I exploit admission thresholds in Sweden's centralized university application system, where small score differences around a cutoff generate quasi-random variation in whether applicants enroll in and complete degrees in their preferred fields. Intuitively, I compare parents who applied to the same field and had nearly identical admission scores, but where some landed just above the relevant cutoff and others just below. I use this cutoff-induced variation in a fuzzy regression discontinuity design to estimate the causal effect of a parent's specialization on the field their child chooses. The identifying assumption is that applicants cannot precisely manipulate on which side of a cutoff they land, and I show that balance and placebo tests support this assumption.

I find large causal spillovers in educational specialization. When a parent earns a degree in a broad field, the probability that the child graduates from that same field rises by 46%, from a baseline of 10.1%. The effects are positive in almost every field, but especially large in technology and medicine. They are economically substantial, but in relative terms still smaller than the intergenerational associations, implying that both parental field choice and broader family background matter for field persistence.

I next show that field inheritance runs through occupational pathways. Controlling for how representative a parent's job is of their field cuts the estimated effect roughly in half, and the effect turns negative when parental graduation predicts low earnings. Yet these patterns are hard to reconcile with comparative advantage as the main explanation. Parental STEM enrollment raises children's ninth-grade math scores by 0.18 standard deviations, indicating some skill transmission, but these gains do not translate into higher labor-market returns. If anything, the causal earnings returns to enrolling in a preferred field are about 30% lower for children who follow their parent.

Instead, the results fit role model and accessibility channels better. The strongest aggregate influence runs from fathers to sons, and mothers influence children of both genders. Some of the clearest field-level effects arise when parents enroll in fields that go against gender stereotypes. Fathers have especially large effects in humanities and health, while mothers' effects are unusually strong in technology. These patterns suggest that parents shape which fields feel accessible and worth pursuing, not just the skills children bring to them.

This paper contributes to two strands of literature. First, it provides rare causal evidence on direct intergenerational transmission in educational specialization, complementing broader work on causal parent-to-child education transmission,[1]. It extends the closest causal comparison, Dahl et al. (2024), from high school majors to university fields. Because university specialization is more tightly linked to occupations, the intergenerational effects I estimate are larger. The gender patterns are nevertheless similar: fathers exert the strongest aggregate influence, especially on sons, and parental influence is stronger in some gender-atypical fields. Unlike Dahl et al. (2024), however, I also find positive spillovers from mothers' enrollment. Second, the paper links field transmission to occupational inheritance and to recent work emphasizing how family background shapes occupational access and the set of careers children consider (Almgren et al. 2025).[2] The lack of support for improved earnings from following a parent is consistent with that view, but contrasts with recent evidence of positive gains from following parents into medicine (Ventura 2023) or the same field more broadly (Birkelund 2024).

Before describing the data, it is useful to explore the descriptive pattern the paper aims to explain. Figure 1 shows that children are much more likely to earn degrees in the same fields as their parents. Off the diagonal, we mainly see negative associations, especially between parents with science degrees and children who graduate from humanities and social science. The purpose of the paper is to answer how much of this pattern reflects a causal effect of parental field choice rather than shared family background.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. The next section describes the institutional setting and the data. It is followed by a description of the empirical framework. I then present the main results, examine the mechanisms behind field inheritance, and conclude.

2 Institutional background and data

This section describes the centralized admission system, the linked administrative data, and how raw applications are converted into the sample used in the regression discontinuity design. The focus here is on the institutional details needed to understand the source of cutoff variation and the composition of the estimation sample. Section 3 formalizes the empirical design. Appendix Section A provides a more detailed description of the education system.

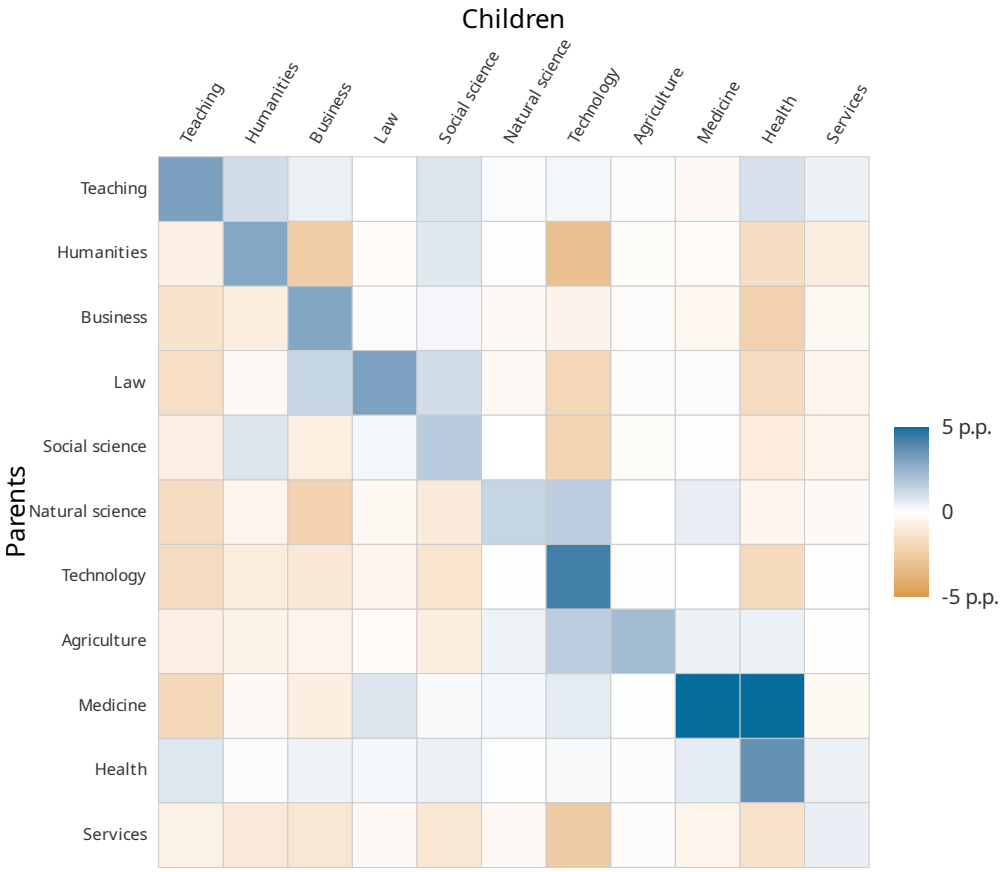
Swedish tertiary education is tuition-free and state run. Applicants submit ranked lists of program-institution combinations through a centralized admission system, and completed programs award field-specific degrees. When a program is oversubscribed, applicants are ranked by admission score. In contrast to some American institutions, there is no legacy admissions channel, and children receive no mechanical advantage from applying to the same program as their parents.

I use university application data from the centralized admission system for 1977–2023. Recent applications (2008–2023) come from Universitets- och Högskolerådet (UHR), while older applications

1. See e.g., Holmlund et al. (2011), Lundborg et al. (2014), and Oreopoulos et al. (2006).

2. For related work on occupational inheritance through skills, networks, rents, and entry barriers, see e.g. Aina and Nicoletti (2018), Kramarz and Skans (2014), Laband and Lentz (1983), Mocetti (2016), and Mocetti et al. (2022).

Figure 1. Degrees of children and parents



Notes: The figure shows the descriptive association between the fields in which parents and children earn degrees. Each cell reports the difference in the share of children with a degree in field j (columns) between parents who hold a degree in field f (rows) and parents who do not, in percentage points. A positive value means that children of field-f parents are more likely to earn a degree in field j than children of parents with degrees in other fields. Formally, each cell shows $\hat{\beta}_{fj}$ from $\mathbb{1}[\mathrm{E}_c = j] = \alpha + \beta_{fj} D_{pf} + \varepsilon_{pc}$, where D_{pf} indicates that the parent holds a degree in field f. The sample is restricted to degree-holding parents, drawn from the full population and matched to the birth-cohort distribution of parents in the analysis sample. Observations are weighted so that each parent receives equal total weight.

come from the UHÄ (1977–1992) and VHS (1993–2005) archives at the Swedish National Archives (Riksarkivet). Application data is missing for the fall semester of 1992, and only partial data is available for 2006 and 2007. The full period is used for descriptive analyses and for measuring outcomes, but identification relies on applications submitted during 1977–1992 so that most children are old enough to have made their own university choices by the end of the sample period.

During the identification period, applicants could rank up to 12 program-institution combinations. Application deadlines were in mid-April for the fall semester and mid-October for the spring semester. After the deadline, the admissions agency verified eligibility and calculated admission scores. General eligibility required completed upper secondary school, and many programs also imposed field-specific course requirements, such as prior STEM coursework for engineering.

When programs were oversubscribed, applicants competed in multiple *admission groups*, for example based on upper-secondary grades, work experience, and Högskoleprovet scores. The number of slots in each group was largely set by national rules, with limited room for local adjustment. Applicants were ranked in every admission group for which they were eligible and admitted in the group where they ranked highest. Appendix Section A describes the scoring rules in more detail.

Ties in the score ranking were common because admission scores were coarse. During 1977–1992, ties were first broken by priority rank, so applicants who listed a program higher were prioritized. Any remaining ties were then resolved by lottery. Two or more applicants shared the cutoff score at 84.6% of cutoffs, but because most scores were not exactly at the cutoff, this corresponds to no more than 4.7% of all applications. For cutoffs at the maximum attainable score (5.5% of cutoffs, covering 0.4% of applications), all applicants with the maximum score are tied, so tie-breaking determines admission for the full group.

I link the application records, using pseudonymized personal identifiers, to Statistics Sweden (SCB) data on course-level enrollment, degree completion, upper secondary school performance, socio-economic characteristics, and family links, all observed through 2023. Information on income and birth-related variables, including family links, birth years, and gender, is available from 1968, while most other registers begin in 1990. Information on grandparents' education comes from the 1968 census (Folk- och Bostadsräkningen). These linked registers allow me to follow applicants into adulthood and then connect them to the later educational choices of their children.

2.1 Sample construction and description

To use these data in a regression discontinuity design, I transform raw application records into field-pair observations centered on program cutoffs. I follow the processing pipeline and estimation framework of Kirkebøen et al. (2016), who study a similarly structured Norwegian admission system.

I start from the universe of applications submitted through the centralized admission system during 1977–1992, consisting of N=8,977,937 admission-group-level observations. For each admission group and alternative, I construct the cutoff as the lowest score among admitted applicants. A cutoff is defined only when eligible applicants were also rejected at the end of the admission round. I then drop ineligible or invalid applications, applicants admitted through non-standard admission groups such as the foreign-applicant track, and applicants to institutions that only offer practical programs such as fine arts. This leaves N=7,820,565 usable observations. Restricting the sample to applicants aged 30 or younger leaves N=7,407,305 observations.[3] I then drop dominated alternatives, where a lower-ranked option has

3. Unlike Kirkebøen et al. (2016), I retain all observed applications to preserve power in split-sample analyses. Repeat applicants do not mechanically receive more influence because weight is equalized at the parent level.

a higher cutoff and therefore could never be chosen over the higher-ranked one. Last, I collapse admission groups within each alternative and retain the group where the applicant ranks highest. This leaves 1,878,800 observations.

I use cutoffs, admission status, and scores from the final admission round, but I keep preference rankings from the initial application. Final-round rankings would incorporate applicants' decisions to remain on waiting lists or accept earlier offers and would therefore build post-application selection into the design.[4]

I classify programs into manually constructed broad fields, similar to ISCED-F 1-digit codes, and into a narrow field classification created by Statistics Sweden.[5] I then collapse consecutively ranked options within the same field, keeping only the program-institution combination where the applicant performed best. Applicants whose choice list contains only one field are dropped because they do not provide a well-defined counterfactual field.

Constructing these field measures requires coding programs and courses from several different sources into the SUN2000 system: the three application systems and the SCB-data on enrollment and degree completion. SUN2000 provides field and level codes similar to ISCED, but the coding quality in the data sources vary. Some have no SUN code links, others have only partial coverage, and some use alternative code sets that do not align with the SUN2000 system. Instead of relying on these codes, I build an AI-assisted classifier that uses names, institutions, and other available metadata as input to recode all roughly 300,000 items using the full SUN2000 code book as guidance. I manually verified a small subset of items and found that the classifier substantially improves on existing codes.

I next create observations of ordered pairs of fields. Each observation consists of a treated field j, ranked above, and a control field k, ranked below. I keep all such pairs. Because alternatives ranked below an admission are removed, an applicant can appear below the cutoff for one preferred field and above the cutoff for another. The final data set contains N=175,212 broad-field pairs and N=246,518 narrow-field pairs.[6]

For each field-pair observation, the running variable is the applicant's score minus the relevant cutoff. For applicants exactly at the cutoff, I predict admission using priority ranks and lottery numbers and classify those predicted to be admitted as above the cutoff. This adds around 30,000 observations to the main broad-field sample. I nevertheless report a "donut" RDD that excludes these at-cutoff cases.

I then merge the field-pair data to children's educational outcomes, linking each parent observation to all of the parent's biological and adoptive children. This leaves N=355,996 broad-field and N=492,819 narrow-field parent-child observations.

The main treatment is parental enrollment in field j, defined as registering for at least one course in that field within five years of the initial application. I also report results that instead use degree completion as the treatment, defined as earning a degree in the field within eight years of treatment.

Table 1 summarizes how the sample changes across these steps. The first column covers all university applicants from 1977–1992 who satisfy the age restriction. The second column reports the processed application sample. The third column reports the broad-field RDD sample, further restricted to parents with children born before 2002 and scores within two standard deviations of the cutoff. The fourth

4. Not being able to use final round preference rankings for estimation decreases first stage accuracy substantially, since many applicants accept their first round offers. This is the main reason for why the first stage for admission (the leftmost plots in Figure 4) does not jump from 0 to 1. It is however still better than simply using the initial thresholds, as many applicants are admitted in the second round lowering many initial cutoffs.

5. The classification is called *Utbildningsgrupper* and is part of the Swedish Education Classification system SUN. Appendix Table F.2 reports the mapping between broad and narrow fields.

6. The number of observations reported in the regression tables is slightly lower because of singletons being dropped when including fixed effects.

column characterizes broad-field enrollment compliers, defined as applicants whose enrollment between fields j and k changes with their position relative to the cutoff. Relative to all applicants, the compliers are somewhat more socio-economically advantaged and include slightly fewer individuals with a foreign background.

Table 1. Summary statistics

	All applicants	Admissible applicants	RDD sample	Compliers
Birthyear	1963.56	1963.72	1962.66	1961.85
	(5.24)	(4.96)	(4.51)	(0.10)
Applicant female	53.92%	53.69%	56.68%	50.95%
	(0.50)	(0.50)	(0.50)	(0.01)
Foreign born	4.57%	3.46%	2.98%	2.85%
	(0.21)	(0.18)	(0.17)	(0.00)
Parents foreign born	7.47%	6.28%	5.47%	6.04%
	(0.26)	(0.24)	(0.23)	(0.01)
Parents' earnings (kSEK)	487.13	516.57	526.57	539.97
	(263.21)	(274.08)	(281.11)	(8.47)
Parent has uni. degree	44.51%	51.98%	52.19%	51.26%
	(0.50)	(0.50)	(0.50)	(0.01)
Has children	81.95%	81.95%	100.00%	
	(0.38)	(0.38)	(0.00)	
N. children	1.83	1.85	2.35	2.33
	(1.14)	(1.15)	(0.83)	(0.02)
N. applicants	408,433	119,051	75,645	
N. ranked alternatives	5.40	7.01	7.22	
	(3.74)	(3.64)	(3.64)	
N. ranked broad fields	1.90	2.73	2.86	
	(1.17)	(1.26)	(1.32)	

Notes: The leftmost column includes all applicants to Swedish universities between 1977 and 1992 who apply through the centralized application system and are 30 years or younger at the time of application. The second column includes the applications remaining after the data processing described in this section. The third column describes the broad field RDD sample used in most analyses, including only parents with children born before 2002 and with scores within 2 standard deviations of the cutoff. The first three columns have standard deviations in parentheses. The fourth column characterizes the RDD compliers. Compliers are those who enroll in the treated broad field j if above the cutoff, and not otherwise. They are characterized by running the main estimation but with covariates interacted with enrollment as outcomes (as described in e.g. Angrist et al. (2023)). In this column, standard errors are reported in parentheses.

Table 2 reports summary statistics by broad field, and Appendix Table D.1 reports the corresponding narrow-field statistics. In the broad-field sample, only applicants treated with the field "Other" are excluded. In the narrow-field sample, additional fields are excluded because of small samples or weak first stages. Excluded fields remain in the data as counterfactual fields. The large differences in sample size and first-stage strength across fields matter for how much each field contributes to aggregate estimates. Enrollment below the cutoff reflects applicants who reapply and enroll within five years of the initial application.

Table 2. Summary statistics by parent broad field of study

	Included in sample	N	Share women	Share enrolled below cutoff	First stage (parent enrolls)
Teaching	Yes	32,046	63.5%	31.6%	27.5***
Humanities	Yes	4910	73.6%	21.6%	13.8***
Business	Yes	43,346	50.9%	33.6%	26.7***
Law	Yes	12,019	58.1%	25.3%	22.9***
Social science	Yes	21,612	65.5%	19.0%	28.3***
Natural science	Yes	10,836	51.6%	29.3%	14.1***
Technology	Yes	33,875	39.8%	36.0%	27.0***
Agriculture	Yes	8566	47.7%	28.0%	35.5***
Medicine	Yes	21,386	44.3%	42.0%	32.2***
Health	Yes	28,632	73.3%	33.3%	15.9***
Services	Yes	7584	78.9%	10.3%	14.4***
Other	No	150	37.3%	36.4%	31.3

Notes: The table shows summary statistics by broad fields for the main analysis sample. The first column indicates which fields are included in the analysis. The last column reports the field-specific first-stage coefficient. For narrow fields, see Appendix Table D.1.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

3 Empirical framework

Estimating direct intergenerational transmission of field choice is difficult because parents and children share resources, social networks, genetic endowments, and preferences that shape the educational choices of both generations. I therefore use a pooled multi-cutoff regression discontinuity design that isolates quasi-random variation in whether parents cross the relevant admission cutoff for their preferred field of study.

The design compares parents who applied to the same field and faced nearly identical admission scores, but fell on opposite sides of the relevant cutoff. Pooling many such admission margins allows me to estimate the causal effect of parental threshold-crossing on the educational choices of their children.

For each parent p, child c, treated field j, and next-best field k, I estimate the reduced form equation:

$$\mathbb{1}\left[\mathrm{E}_c = j\right] = \alpha \mathbb{1}\left[a_{pg\tau} \geq 0\right] + f\left(a_{pg\tau}, \theta^g\right) + X_{pj}\mu + \mu_j + \mu_k + \mu_t + \varepsilon_{pcj}, \tag{1}$$

where E_c is the educational outcome of child c. In different specifications, it is an indicator for whether the child applies to, enrolls in, or graduates from the treated field j.

α is the coefficient of interest. It measures the intention-to-treat effect of parental threshold-crossing to field j on the child's educational outcome. Cutoffs are defined at the institution-program-admission-group level: each cutoff (τ) belongs to exactly one admission group (g) and one field (j).

a_{pgj} is the standardized score with which parent p competes in admission group g for field j. Scores are standardized separately by admission group and indexed by j because an applicant's score within a given admission group can vary across fields depending on the upper-secondary courses required for

eligibility (see Appendix A). Let $\bar{a}_\tau$ denote the admission score at cutoff τ. I then define the cutoff-centered running variable as $a_{pg\tau} = a_{pgj} - \bar{a}_\tau$.

Because scoring policies differ across admission groups, I allow the running variable to enter with separate slopes by admission group and on each side of the cutoff:

$$f\left(a_{pg\tau}, \theta^g\right) = \theta_0^g a_{pg\tau} + \theta_1^g a_{pg\tau} \mathbb{1}\left[a_{pg\tau} \geq 0\right], \tag{2}$$

This specification follows Dahl et al. (2024), who use separate slopes for each preferred or next-best upper-secondary program in their most demanding specification. I report a robustness check with two slopes per cutoff in Appendix Table B.5, but rely on the admission-group specification above in the main results.

The specification also includes preferred-field fixed effects μ_j, next-best-field fixed effects μ_k, and year-semester fixed effects μ_t. The control vector X_{pj} includes applicant gender and the priority rank of j in the parent's application, which capture variation in admission probability induced by gender- and priority-based tie-breaking (see Appendix A).

I estimate the reduced form by OLS and the fuzzy RD specifications by 2SLS, after partialling out the fixed effects with the R package fixest (Bergé 2018). Standard errors are clustered at the family level.

Unless otherwise stated, I include applications with scores at most 2 standard deviations away from the cutoff. Since the estimates pool a large set of cutoffs, traditional optimal bandwidth calculations are not especially informative in this setting.[7] I use a bandwidth of 2 because it provides enough precision for disaggregated analyses. Figure 7 shows that the aggregate estimates change little across a wide range of bandwidth choices.

To avoid mechanically overweighting parents who contribute more child-by-application-margin observations (either by applying several times or having more children), I weight each observation by the inverse of the total number of observations contributed by that parent, so each parent receives equal total weight in the pooled estimates. Also for interpretability, I use a uniform kernel that gives equal weight to all observations within the bandwidth. Appendix Table B.9 shows that the results are very similar under a triangular kernel.

Many results are also reported separately by field j. These come from joint estimations in which treatment is interacted with the parent's preferred field. Estimating these coefficients jointly is more precise than running Equation 1 separately for each field because the controls are fit on the full sample.

The data end in 2023, so some children born late in the sample period have not yet reached university application age. Rather than treat them as permanent non-followers, I restrict the main sample to children born before 2002, who could plausibly make their university choices before the end of observation. Appendix Table B.1 shows no evidence of threshold-crossing affecting the likelihood of having children or the timing of their births, which reduces concern that this restriction induces substantial post-treatment selection.

3.1 Identifying assumptions and validation

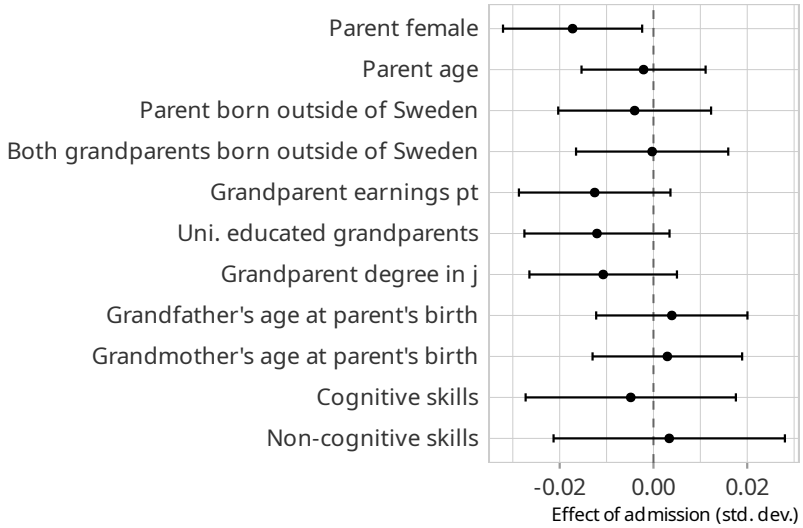
The key identifying assumption is local continuity at the cutoff: absent treatment, applicants just above and just below a cutoff should have similar potential outcomes. This assumption would be threatened if applicants could precisely sort around the cutoff (Lee and Lemieux 2010). The first validation exercise

7. Calonico et al. (2014) optimal bandwidths, calculated on the pooled and demeaned data, range from 0.8 to 2, depending on the specification.

therefore examines whether threshold-crossing is related to predetermined characteristics, and the second examines whether applicants bunch around the cutoff.

Figure 2 assesses covariate continuity by replacing the left-hand side of Equation 1 with standardized pre-treatment characteristics. If admission is locally as-good-as random, threshold-crossing should not predict these variables. Only one coefficient is statistically different from zero: threshold-crossing is associated with a 0.4 percentage point lower probability that the applicant is female. This isolated and economically small imbalance is not enough to suggest systematic sorting around the cutoff.

Figure 2. Balance plot



Notes: The plot shows covariate balance tests for a number of parent characteristics that are defined before treatment. Each row represents a separate regression, where a standardized characteristic has been regressed on threshold-crossing. Otherwise, the sample and specification is the same as in the main analysis. Information on cognitive and non-cognitive skills is only available for a small, male-only subset of the population.

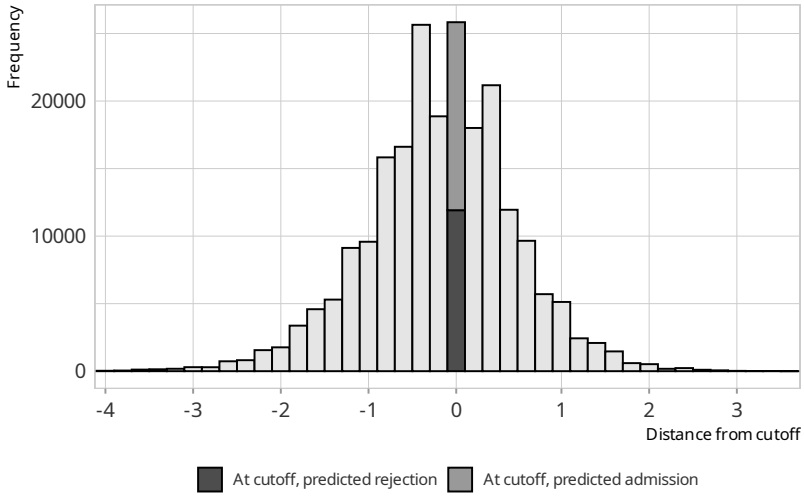
Figure 3 examines sorting more directly by plotting the pooled score distribution around the cutoff. There is no visible bunching on either side of the threshold. Applicants exactly at the cutoff are shown in a separate bin because tie-breaking determines their admission status. The figure excludes cutoffs that require a perfect score, since bunching there is mechanical rather than evidence of manipulation. In the main analysis, those cutoffs are retained and at-cutoff applicants are classified using their tie-breaking information. Table B.7 and Table B.8 show that the main results are very similar when those observations are excluded.

3.2 Threshold-crossing as an instrument

Equation 1 identifies an intention-to-treat effect of parental threshold-crossing. Because many parents who cross a cutoff do not ultimately enroll in or complete a degree in the relevant field, I also estimate fuzzy RD specifications that use threshold-crossing as an instrument for parental enrollment or degree completion.

For the 2SLS estimates to recover local average treatment effects (LATEs), the exclusion restriction must hold: threshold-crossing can affect child outcomes only through parental treatment. For

Figure 3. Histogram of the running variable



Notes: Histogram of the running variable around the cutoff. Applicants exactly at the cutoff are sorted separately and the shade of the middle bar indicates whether the tie-breaking mechanism predicts that they will be admitted. Cutoffs where a perfect score is required for admission have been excluded.

enrollment, this assumption is relatively plausible because parents who are admitted but never enroll receive no field-specific education. A more relevant concern is that threshold-crossing may change the timing of education: applicants just below the cutoff may reapply and eventually enroll, potentially delaying graduation, labor market entry, or childbearing. If so, threshold-crossing could affect child outcomes through timing rather than through enrollment itself. Appendix Table B.1 shows no evidence of threshold-crossing affecting the likelihood of having children or the timing of their births, which reduces concern that this restriction induces substantial post-treatment selection. The table does show an effect on the timing of enrollment and degree completion, however. This is caused by always-takers who re-apply. To safeguard from treatment misclassification due to reapplication-induced delays, I define enrollment over a five-year window after the initial application and degree completion over an eight-year window.

Degree completion is closer to the substantive object of interest, but it is a less clean IV target. The longer lag between admission and degree completion creates more scope for exclusion to fail, and parents who never complete a degree may still accumulate field-specific skills or credits that affect their children's later choices. I therefore report IV estimates for both enrollment and degree completion, but treat enrollment as the primary specification and degree completion as a secondary, more assumption-sensitive measure.

Monotonicity also matters for the LATE interpretation. Crossing the threshold should not make any applicant less likely to enroll in the preferred field j relative to remaining below the cutoff. Because j is ranked above k, and lower-ranked options are discarded when applicants are admitted to higher-ranked ones, this condition is plausible for the field pairs used here. The admission mechanism is not fully strategy proof, so this ranking-based argument is strongest when j is ranked first. Table B.6 shows very similar results in that restricted sample.

With many possible fields, the field-to-field LATE interpretation also relies on the *irrelevance* condition emphasized by Kirkebøen et al. (2016). It requires that if crossing the threshold to j does not induce

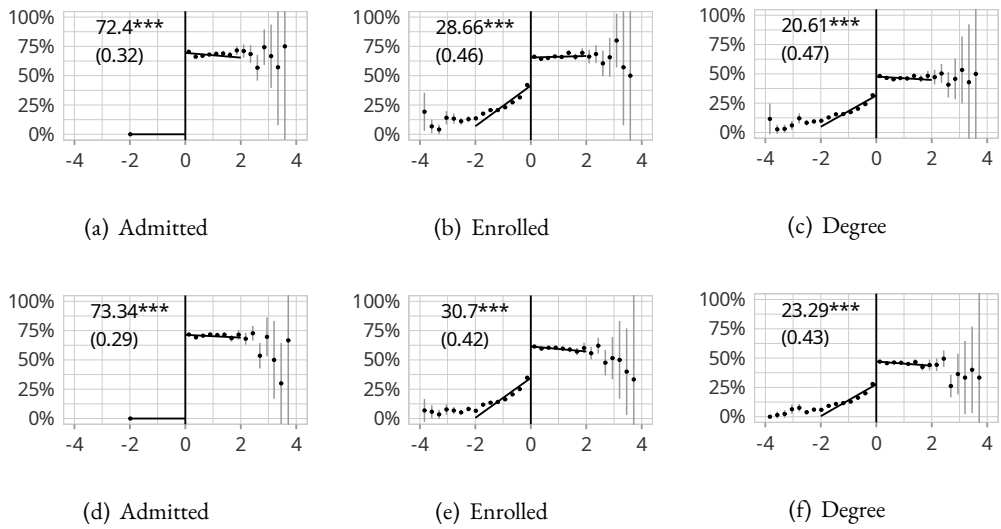
treatment in j, it also does not shift the applicant into some third field j'. Conditional on next-best-field fixed effects, this rules out off-margin substitutions from driving the IV estimates. The condition is more plausible for enrollment than for degree completion: admission primarily affects whether applicants start field j, whereas partial progress in j may later facilitate degree completion in related fields.

Two recent papers highlight, in this fuzzy-RD 2SLS setting, the tradeoff between a more saturated specification and statistical precision. Blandhol et al. (2025) show that covariate-adjusted 2SLS has a clean LATE interpretation only under sufficiently rich covariate adjustment, while Fort et al. (2022) show that, in multi-cutoff RD designs with observations at the cutoff, the safest approach is to include site fixed effects, where the natural site here is the cutoff. The main specification includes fixed effects for both the preferred and next-best field, which absorb important differences across admission margins in baseline outcomes and treatment compliance while preserving precision for the analyses that follow. This only partially addresses those concerns, however, because the baseline still pools cutoffs within fields rather than allowing each cutoff to enter with its own fixed effect. Appendix Table B.4 reports the corresponding aggregate specifications with cutoff fixed effects, and these estimates are very similar to the baseline results. I therefore view the field-pooled specification as a practical compromise: it is less finely saturated than the cutoff-fixed-effect alternative, but the similarity of the two sets of estimates suggests that residual within-field heterogeneity across cutoffs is not the main driver of the results.

Finally, a meaningful IV interpretation also requires a relevant first stage. Figure 4 and Table C.1 show clear jumps at the cutoff for parental admission, enrollment, and degree completion. All IV results tables report first-stage Wald statistics well above conventional weak-instrument thresholds.

Overall, I treat the enrollment-based IV estimates as the paper's main IV results and as the cleanest LATE interpretation. Degree-completion IV estimates are substantively informative, but they rely on stronger exclusion and irrelevance assumptions and should therefore be interpreted more cautiously.

Figure 4. Treatment take-up around the cutoff for broad (top) and narrow (bottom) fields



(a) Admitted (b) Enrolled (c) Degree

(d) Admitted (e) Enrolled (f) Degree

Notes: The plot shows admission, enrollment, degree completion in the preferred field j above and below the cutoff. The top three plots show broad fields, and the bottom three narrow fields. Admission score is standardized by admission group and centered at the cutoff. Applicants with a score exactly at the cutoff but where a tie-breaking mechanism has ensured they are not admitted have been included in the bin below the cutoff. All parents from the main study sample are included, but observations are not repeated for each child. First stage coefficients from Table C.1 are reported in percentage points within each plot, with standard errors in parentheses. The reason threshold-crossing increases admission by no more than about 70 percentage points is mainly because some individuals who would have been admitted withdraw their application after the first round.

4 Main results

Table 3 reports the main results. Parental enrollment increases the likelihood that a child earns a degree in the same broad field by 3.3 percentage points, or 33% relative to the control mean. The corresponding estimate is larger when treatment is defined as parental degree completion, at 4.6 percentage points (46%). For narrow fields, the effects are smaller in percentage points but larger in relative terms, at 2.2 percentage points (54%) for parental enrollment and 3.0 percentage points (71%) for parental degree completion. The effects on child enrollment and first-ranked applications are of similar magnitude: 22% and 23% for broad fields, and 44% and 41% for narrow fields when parental enrollment is the treatment; the corresponding degree-based estimates are 30%, 32%, 58%, and 54%. As a benchmark, the degree-to-degree effects of 46% and 71% can be compared to the aggregate associations of 89% and 307%.

The aggregate effects are weighted averages of heterogeneous treatment effects for various fields of study. Figure 5 displays a coefficient plot of the broad field IV estimates using enrollment as treatment.

Several patterns stand out. The effect of parental enrollment varies substantially by field. For child degree completion, technology, medicine, and business exhibit the largest significant effects. At the application and enrollment margins, law and humanities also stand out, but these effects weaken sharply

Table 3. Aggregate field inheritance

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	6.69%	6.26%	9.40%	12.65%	13.42%	16.55%
	1.45^{***}	1.28^{***}	0.95^{***}	1.23^{***}	0.99^{***}	0.69^{***}
	(0.34)	(0.34)	(0.25)	(0.23)	(0.21)	(0.16)
Parent enrolls in j	23.35%	21.83%	32.79%	41.20%	43.70%	53.92%
	5.06^{***}	4.46^{***}	3.30^{***}	4.00^{***}	3.23^{***}	2.24^{***}
	(1.19)	(1.17)	(0.89)	(0.75)	(0.68)	(0.51)
Parent receives degree in j	32.47%	30.36%	45.60%	54.31%	57.61%	71.08%
	7.03^{***}	6.21^{***}	4.59^{***}	5.27^{***}	4.26^{***}	2.96^{***}
	(1.65)	(1.63)	(1.23)	(0.99)	(0.90)	(0.67)
Observations	224,810	224,810	224,810	256,941	256,941	256,941
Control group mean	21.66%	20.45%	10.07%	9.71%	7.39%	4.16%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	3863	3863	3863	5287	5287	5287
1st stage Wald (degree)	1886	1886	1886	2955	2955	2955
Bandwidth	2.0	2.0	2.0	2.0	2.0	2.0

Notes: Each row of coefficients comes from different specifications: Reduced form results at the top followed by IV estimates for parental enrollment and degree completion. Effect sizes relative to the control group mean are reported for convenience at the top of each row. Coefficients and standard errors are reported in percentage points. All regressions use a bandwidth of 2 std, a uniform kernel, and include separate slopes by admission group score, above and below the cutoff. Fixed-effects for preferred and next-best field, semester, priority rank, and gender are also included. Standard errors are clustered at the family level.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

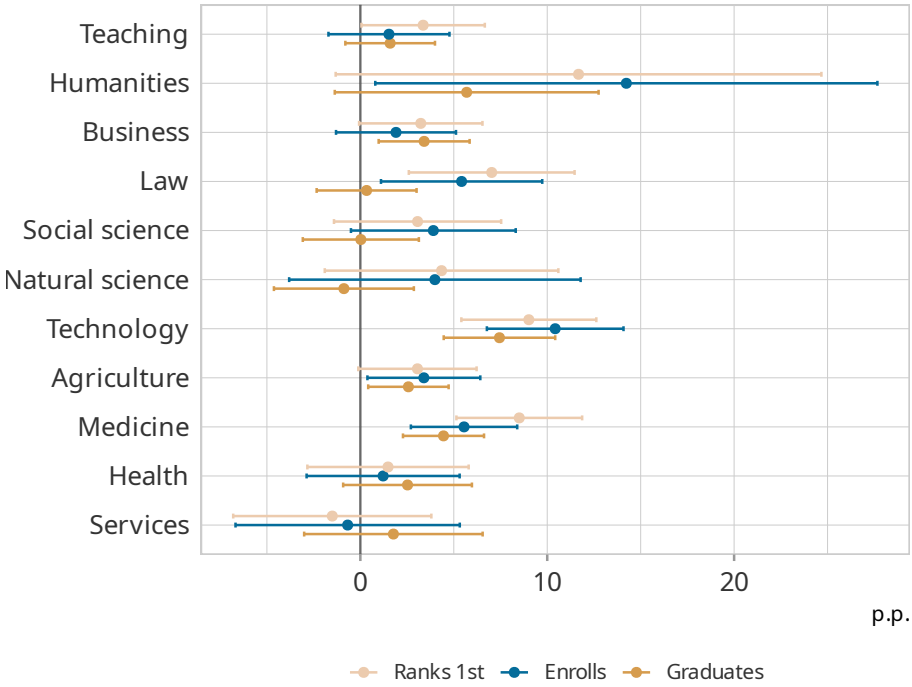
by graduation. Few point estimates are negative, and those that are tend to be small and insignificant. Compared to the intergenerational associations in Appendix Table C.3, the relative causal effects are considerably smaller for some fields but not for others.

Appendix Section D presents the same analysis with applications collapsed by narrow fields. Figure D.2 shows business, law, and medicine among the strongest results, but the effect for technology is harder to discern. A likely reason is that many applicants in this specification end up at margins between different engineering subfields, which dilutes the broad-field treatment contrast. Only M.Sc.-level electrical engineering exhibits a clearly strong positive effect. While the plot reports a few negative estimates, none are significant and most are very small.

Parental education could also affect the likelihood that a child studies related fields. Figure 6 reports RD estimates of parental enrollment on child degree completion in a heatmap, with separate regressions for each child field. The diagonal again shows the familiar pattern from Figure 5, but there are also suggestive off-diagonal spillovers. In particular, the medicine column is positive for many parental fields, whereas the technology column is often negative. Appendix Figure C.2 reports the corresponding effects on child enrollment. Because those estimates are more precise, the same broad patterns appear more clearly there.[8]

8. A pattern that is clearer for child enrollment than for degree completion is that humanities enrollment appears to be positively influenced by parental enrollment in most fields except technology and medicine. One possible explanation is that students take humanities courses as part of degrees in other fields. This is less true for medicine and technology, which are often taught at separate institutions with fewer opportunities for such cross-field enrollment.

Figure 5. Inheritance of fields of study (broad fields)

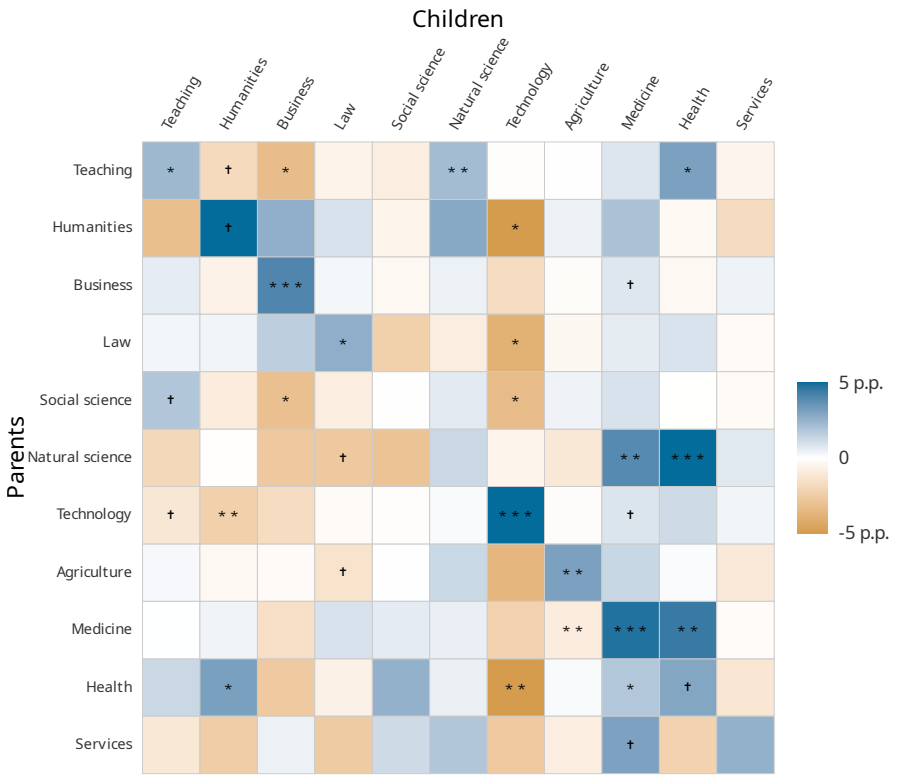


Notes: The figure reports coefficients of parental enrollment on child application, enrollment, and degree completion using the same specification as in Table 3 but with a separate coefficient estimated for each preferred field j. The exact coefficients and relative effects are reported in Table C.2. The fields are sorted by how they map to narrow fields. Corresponding results for narrow fields are reported in Appendix Figure D.2 and Table D.2.

Overall, the matrix suggests spillovers across related fields rather than only exact field matches. The broad spillovers into medicine and out of technology are especially striking, while comparable patterns are less evident for law and business. Given the noise in the off-diagonal estimates, these patterns should be interpreted cautiously.

Before turning to the mechanisms in Section 6, the next section subjects these results to a range of robustness checks.

Figure 6. Cross-field inheritance matrix



Notes: The matrix reports regression coefficients of parental field enrollment on child degree completion. Appendix Figure C.2 reports the corresponding effect on child enrollment. Estimation is done using the same setup as in Table 3. The colors are capped at effect sizes between -3 and 3 percentage points, since outliers (usually field combinations with few observations) would otherwise cause most cells to be indistinguishable from zero. Significance levels are not corrected for multiple comparisons. $+\ p \leq 0.1, *\ p \leq 0.05, **\ p \leq 0.01, ***\ p \leq 0.001$.

5 Robustness

Regression discontinuity designs put strong requirements on the data. As discussed above, the main identifying assumption stipulates that the control function needs to be continuous at the cutoff. In other words, if not for admission, nothing would differ between applicants just above and below the cutoff. Since the exact level of the cutoff changes each year, applicants cannot know with certainty whether they will be admitted before applying, meaning that there is no way to precisely manipulate admission status by choosing where to apply. Section 3 presented validation checks supporting this assumption. This section goes further in evaluating the validity of the RDD design and the robustness of the main results.

We saw in Figure 2 that parental admission is not significantly related to any of the plotted pre-treatment characteristics except gender. An additional way to check that parents at the margin are not somehow able to select into the field they prefer is through the placebo analysis presented in Table 4. The estimation uses the same setup as the main analysis, but evaluates the effect of the child's quasi-random admission on parental educational outcomes. Since parents are educated before their children, we should not see any effects. But if the identifying assumptions fail, and applicants are somehow able to manipulate their admission status, the intergenerational field of study correlation should carry over to these estimates. Thankfully, Table 4 reports no significant results. This indicates that the RDD estimates do not erroneously capture spurious selection into fields within families.

Table 4. Placebo (parent outcomes regressed on child threshold-crossing)

	Parent educated in broad field			Parent educated in narrow field		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Child above cutoff	0.05	−0.12	−0.13	−0.24	−0.24	−0.17
	(0.25)	(0.28)	(0.24)	(0.17)	(0.17)	(0.16)
Observations	237,542	237,542	237,542	284,281	284,281	284,281
Control group mean	11.9%	14.55%	10.29%	6.75%	5.91%	5.29%

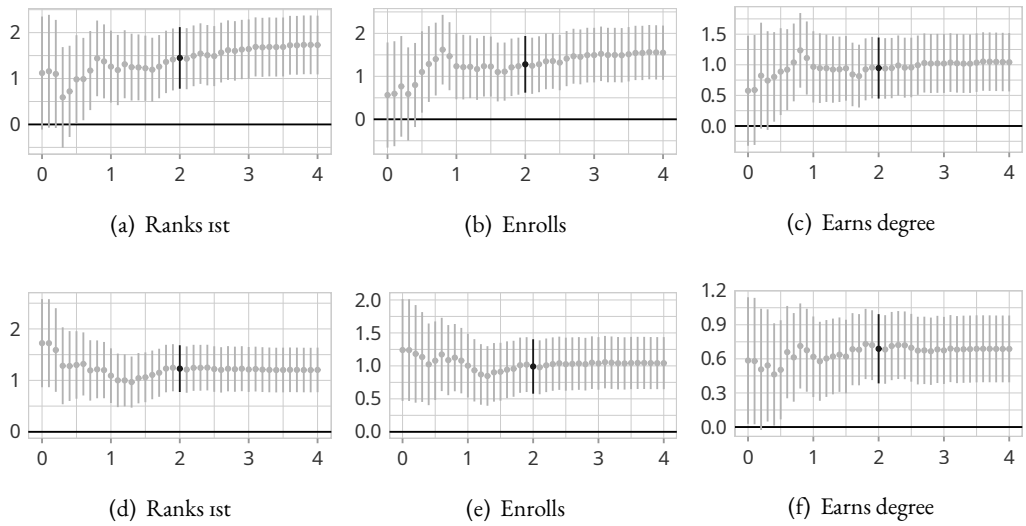
Notes: The table shows results from a placebo estimation where the admission status of the child is used to study the choices of the parent. Since the parent's application happened long before the child's, we expect to see no pattern. First stage statistics are reported in Table B.2.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

The choice of bandwidth is an important design decision in RDD analysis. A bandwidth that is too small may lead to high variance and unstable estimates, while a bandwidth that is too large may introduce bias. Figure 7 shows reduced form estimates for various bandwidths. In normal RDD analyses, established optimal bandwidth procedures yield balanced bandwidth choices. But since I am pooling a large set of quasi-experiments, such calculations couldn't possibly be optimal for all cutoffs. Instead, I use a bandwidth of 2 standard deviations for all analyses (marked in a darker color in the plot). The figure shows little variation in the size of the effects as the bandwidth changes, except for very small bandwidths.

Additional robustness and validity checks are performed in Appendix Section B. Figure B.1 shows that the effect disappears when the admission cutoff is moved away from zero. Table B.3 adds quadratic slopes for each admission group with little impact on results. Table B.5 instead adds separate linear slopes

Figure 7. Reduced form results by bandwidth size



Notes: Each plot shows the main reduced form effect of a parent being above the cutoff on their child's first ranked application, enrollment, and degree completion. The leftmost bar in each plot has a bandwidth of zero and only includes applicants exactly at the cutoff where different tie-breaking mechanisms were used to allocate students. I use a bandwidth of 2 standard deviations for all analyses, marked in a darker color in the plot.

for each cutoff. While highly imprecise and fraught with convergence problems in estimation, most results stay economically meaningful in this specification. The results in Table B.6 are based on a sample where only those fields that were ranked first by the parent are included, to overcome potential problems with incentive compatibility. These results are again very similar to the main findings, but slightly less precise. Table B.7 and Table B.8 show that the results stay approximately the same when excluding observations exactly at the cutoff, and when excluding cutoffs where a perfect score is required for admission. Finally, Table B.9 uses a triangular instead of uniform kernel with little impact on results.

6 Why are fields inherited?

The previous sections demonstrated a strong and robust causal relationship between the field of study choices of parents and their children. But what is this effect capturing? Why are university fields inherited? Previous work on intergenerational persistence of advantage normally studies occupational inheritance. This section first asks to what extent the measured field effect is tied to occupations and labor market outcomes. Occupational inheritance is often explained by child comparative advantage, so I then investigate whether parental field enrollment gives children such advantages. Finally, I evaluate an alternative hypothesis: that fields are inherited because parents act as role models and make their chosen field relatively more salient and accessible.

6.1 Labor market experience

Swedes often have their first child after graduating university. In the studied sample, parents are on average 21 years old when they apply to university for the first time and 51 when their children apply. Such a long time span makes it plausible that much of the estimated effect operates through the later labor market experience of parents. There are few other pathways through which a treatment at university application could persist for so long, and while few occupations have legal licensing requirements, a university diploma is often the most effective way to gain entry.[9] If field transmission partly reflects occupational inheritance, measures of later labor market outcomes should attenuate the effect. Table 5 includes three likely mediators, measured in midlife: occupation-field representativeness (panel B.)[10], log earnings (panel C.), and months in unemployment (panel D.). All three attenuate the RD estimates, especially for broad fields, but occupation-field representativeness is by far the strongest. Including all three in the same model (panel E.) captures little more than conditioning on representativeness alone. Because these mediators are post-treatment, they could be affected by other factors. The pattern is nonetheless consistent with field inheritance being stronger when parents later work in occupations that are typical for their field, while actual earnings and unemployment explain less of the variation.

The included mediators are endogenous, and their attenuating effect could reflect other factors. Table 6 therefore turns to three measures of treatment "quality" that are fixed at the time of enrollment: the score required for admission, the average GPA of enrolled peers, and the parent's predicted log earnings conditional on graduating from j, an ex ante measure of expected labor market success. These interactions do not identify a mechanism either, but they are informative about which parental field experiences are most likely to influence child field choice. Predicted earnings show the clearest gradient: inheritance is weaker, and can even turn negative, in fields with relatively poor predicted labor market outcomes. The average peer GPA interaction points in the same direction but is less precisely estimated, while the threshold score interaction is close to zero throughout.

Taken together, Tables 5 and 6 are most consistent with field inheritance operating through parents' later labor market exposure rather than through the admission margin itself. Appendix Table C.10 provides a related check by interacting enrollment with parent age when the child is 18 and about to apply to university. The effect is concentrated among parents of prime working age, consistent with active occupational exposure mattering more than distant educational experiences.

These patterns establish that parents transmit fields primarily through the careers those fields lead to. But they leave open what exactly is transmitted: field-specific skills that give children a comparative advantage, or something less tangible, like familiarity and accessibility?

9. For at least a part of the studied period, the following fields allowed graduates to pursue occupational licenses: medicine, nursing, law, architecture, teaching, dentistry, psychology, and pharmacy.

10. Defined as the log location quotient (equivalent to the pointwise mutual information (PMI) measure), i.e. the log of the share of 3-digit occupation workers among graduates of a given field divided by the frequency of the occupation in the population.

Table 5. Mediation by labor market experience

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
A. Base model (reduced form)						
Parent above cutoff to j	0.73^{**}	0.86^{***}	0.48^{**}	0.73^{***}	0.74^{***}	0.44^{***}
	(0.24)	(0.24)	(0.17)	(0.15)	(0.14)	(0.10)
B. Occupation-field representativeness (age 40-49)						
Parent above cutoff to j	0.29	$0.41^{\dagger}$	0.23	0.48^{**}	0.51^{***}	0.33^{**}
	(0.24)	(0.24)	(0.17)	(0.15)	(0.14)	(0.10)
Log LQ	1.41^{***}	1.41^{***}	0.80^{***}	0.79^{***}	0.74^{***}	0.39^{***}
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.02)
C. Average inflation adjusted log kSEK earnings (age 45-49)						
Parent above cutoff to j	0.67^{**}	0.78^{**}	0.44^{**}	0.69^{***}	0.71^{***}	0.43^{***}
	(0.24)	(0.24)	(0.17)	(0.15)	(0.14)	(0.10)
Log earnings	2.98^{***}	3.50^{***}	1.78^{***}	2.11^{***}	2.01^{***}	1.15^{***}
	(0.13)	(0.13)	(0.09)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.06)
D. Months in unemployment (age 40-49)						
Parent above cutoff to j	0.71^{**}	0.84^{***}	0.47^{**}	0.71^{***}	0.73^{***}	0.44^{***}
	(0.24)	(0.24)	(0.17)	(0.15)	(0.14)	(0.10)
Months unemployed	-0.20^{***}	-0.19^{***}	-0.12^{***}	-0.12^{***}	-0.10^{***}	-0.06^{***}
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.00)
E. All mediators						
Parent above cutoff to j	0.28	$0.41^{\dagger}$	0.23	0.49^{**}	0.52^{***}	0.33^{**}
	(0.24)	(0.24)	(0.17)	(0.15)	(0.14)	(0.10)
Log LQ	1.22^{***}	1.19^{***}	0.69^{***}	0.67^{***}	0.63^{***}	0.32^{***}
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.02)
Log earnings	2.24^{***}	2.83^{***}	1.36^{***}	1.67^{***}	1.62^{***}	0.93^{***}
	(0.13)	(0.13)	(0.09)	(0.09)	(0.09)	(0.06)
Months unemployed	-0.12^{***}	-0.10^{***}	-0.07^{***}	-0.06^{***}	-0.04^{***}	-0.03^{***}
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.00)
Observations	316,891	316,891	316,891	370,910	370,910	370,910
Control group mean	13.68%	13.99%	6.37%	5.96%	5.05%	2.59%

Notes: The table presents a mediation analysis of equation 1, where three potential mediators, measured in midlife, are included on their own (panels B-D.) and together (panel E.). Occupation-field representativeness is operationalized as the log location quotient of the parent's modal 3-digit occupation in their treatment field. The other variables are self-explanatory.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table 6. Field inheritance by ex ante treatment quality

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
A. Admission group threshold score (std)						
Parent enrolls in j	4.05*	4.10*	3.32**	3.30***	2.69**	2.17***
	(1.60)	(1.60)	(1.21)	(0.94)	(0.87)	(0.64)
× Threshold score	1.14	0.41	0.02	0.74	0.55	0.10
	(0.77)	(0.77)	(0.58)	(0.48)	(0.44)	(0.33)
Threshold score	−0.71*	−0.25	−0.18	−0.02	0.09	−0.07
	(0.36)	(0.36)	(0.26)	(0.20)	(0.18)	(0.13)
B. Average GPA of enrollees in j (std)						
Parent enrolls in j	1.95	2.62	1.88	1.28	0.91	1.16
	(1.88)	(1.84)	(1.40)	(1.19)	(1.07)	(0.80)
× Avg. GPA enrolled	3.48*	2.05†	1.60†	2.79**	2.40**	1.08†
	(1.36)	(1.23)	(0.94)	(0.91)	(0.80)	(0.60)
Avg. GPA enrolled	−8.65***	−5.60***	−3.80***	−3.33***	−2.25***	−2.23***
	(1.19)	(1.13)	(0.83)	(0.70)	(0.63)	(0.46)
C. Predicted log earnings						
Parent enrolls in j	−37.82***	−29.65**	−25.32**	−32.97***	−29.17***	−18.04***
	(11.33)	(10.79)	(8.01)	(7.68)	(6.82)	(4.85)
× Predicted log earnings	6.98***	5.55**	4.67***	5.95***	5.21***	3.27***
	(1.83)	(1.74)	(1.29)	(1.25)	(1.11)	(0.79)
Predicted log earnings	0.59	2.25*	−0.70	0.72	0.94	−0.70
	(1.16)	(1.11)	(0.81)	(0.83)	(0.74)	(0.54)

Notes: Parental enrollment is interacted with three continuous measures of ex ante field quality: minimum required standardized admission group score in the group the applicant competed in (A.), average standardized upper secondary school GPA of field enrollees (B.), and predicted log earnings (at age 40-45, inflation-adjusted kSEK). Earnings are predicted from field-gender dummies as well as dummies for pre-treatment characteristics like upper secondary school GPA, parental earnings, and immigrant status. The estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

6.2 Do children who follow their parents gain a comparative advantage?

Occupational persistence across generations is well documented in the social sciences. Economists often explain this persistence by children acquiring a comparative advantage in their parents' occupations through transfers of occupation-specific resources. This could reflect "dinner-table" conversations (Hvide and Oyer 2018), internships at family firms (Laband and Lentz 1992), or broader exposure to the right social endowments (Bell et al. 2019). Such transfers can be productivity-improving, as with human-capital transmission, or they can simply improve access. Cases where parental resources help a child advance over better-qualified candidates are usually labeled nepotism. The distinction matters: productivity-improving transmission can improve matching, while nepotism can distort it, for example when family-based appointments lower firm performance (Bennedsen et al. 2007) or family ties raise access to employers (Staiger 2023).[11] This section asks whether parental field enrollment gives children such advantages.

11. Several other key papers are worth mentioning. Lentz and Laband (1989) show that children of doctors are more likely to be admitted to medical school, and Laband and Lentz (1983) that farmers tend to be sons of farmers because the experience they gain while growing up gives them a comparative advantage. Dunn and Holtz-Eakin (2000) argue that the transition to

We begin by studying the direct transfer of human capital from parents to their children. Table 7 presents RDD estimates of parental field enrollment on child subject-level test scores from grade 9.[12] The evidence is noisy and does not support a broad pattern across fields, but a few estimates are consistent with subject-specific skill transmission. Technology improves math scores, humanities improve language scores, and business modestly improves social science scores. Table 8 reports estimates from a specification where only applicants on the STEM/non-STEM margin are included, and that margin generates the clearest result: STEM enrollment improves child math knowledge. Overall, parental field enrollment appears able to shape some related skills, but the evidence is limited and uneven across subjects and fields.

Table 7. Parental field enrollment and child test scores

Field	Languages		Social science		Math		Natural science	
Teaching	0.00	(0.04)	$0.16^{\dagger}$	(0.09)	0.02	(0.05)	−0.02	(0.06)
Humanities	0.23^{*}	(0.11)	$0.36^{\dagger}$	(0.19)	−0.04	(0.13)	0.31^{*}	(0.15)
Business	0.03	(0.03)	0.09^{*}	(0.04)	0.03	(0.03)	−0.01	(0.04)
Law	0.07	(0.04)	$0.12^{\dagger}$	(0.06)	0.01	(0.05)	0.04	(0.06)
Social science	−0.06	(0.04)	−0.05	(0.07)	−0.03	(0.05)	−0.06	(0.06)
Natural science	0.05	(0.07)	0.05	(0.11)	0.06	(0.09)	0.06	(0.10)
Technology	$0.06^{\dagger}$	(0.03)	0.08	(0.05)	0.13^{***}	(0.03)	0.04	(0.04)
Agriculture	−0.06	(0.05)	0.04	(0.08)	−0.01	(0.05)	−0.04	(0.06)
Medicine	0.01	(0.03)	0.08	(0.06)	0.02	(0.04)	0.06	(0.05)
Health	0.03	(0.05)	0.13	(0.10)	−0.01	(0.06)	−0.04	(0.08)
Services	0.01	(0.09)	0.23	(0.15)	0.14	(0.11)	−0.04	(0.14)
Aggregate	0.02	(0.02)	0.08^{*}	(0.04)	0.04	(0.03)	0.01	(0.03)

Notes: The table shows RDD estimates of parental field enrollment on child test scores in different subjects. Each outcome is an average of standardized (at the test+cohort level) 9th grade national test scores in courses that fall within the respective subjects.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table 8. Parental field enrollment and child test scores (STEM margin only)

Field	Languages		Social science		Math		Natural science	
non-STEM	0.04	(0.10)	0.21	(0.16)	−0.03	(0.11)	−0.05	(0.13)
STEM	0.04	(0.05)	0.08	(0.08)	0.17^{**}	(0.05)	0.05	(0.06)

Notes: This table reproduces Table 7 but on a data set where applications have been collapsed along the STEM/non-STEM margin. The first row thus shows LATEs for individuals on the margin to a non-STEM program, with a STEM program as their next-best, and the second row shows the corresponding LATEs for individuals on the margin to STEM.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

self-employment is better predicted by parental self-employment success than individual or parental financial resources. Dal Bó et al. (2009) use discontinuities in election outcomes to show that political success builds dynasties, and Mocetti (2016) and Mocetti et al. (2022) exploit deregulation in Italy to show that a decline in occupation-specific rents together with increased competition reduces intergenerational persistence.

12. Grade 9 scores are not affected by selection from tracking which starts in upper secondary school. They are also less influenced by grade inflation and non-cognitive skills than 9th grade GPA. However, unreported estimates from 9th grade subject-level GPA yield similar results.

Limited evidence of subject-specific skill transmission does not imply that children earn higher labor market returns when they follow their parents. Table 9 evaluates this claim and reports results from an RDD specification of field enrollment on earnings 10-14 years later. This analysis is based on a different sample than the main specification: it includes all applications until 2010. Enrollment is interacted with an indicator variable for whether at least one of the applicant's parents has a degree in the treated field.[13] While parental degrees are fixed before treatment, the interaction coefficients could be correlated with unobserved factors and should not be interpreted causally.

Table 9. Field returns by parental degree

Field	Earnings (10-14 years)		× parent	
Teaching	−11.58	(21.35)	−5.86	(22.88)
Humanities	−11.75	(31.79)	−22.33	(59.73)
Business	88.55***	(17.86)	−47.66†	(25.75)
Law	53.25***	(14.04)	57.76	(40.17)
Social science	21.73	(14.94)	−18.28	(24.83)
Natural science	−33.68	(25.05)	−55.40	(52.75)
Technology	65.82***	(12.93)	32.19†	(18.02)
Agriculture	11.53	(12.15)	−26.56	(27.18)
Medicine	103.36***	(12.50)	4.25	(22.92)
Health	5.10	(12.81)	20.05	(13.11)
Services	21.90	(23.32)	51.00	(65.09)
Aggregate	56.60***	(8.66)	−16.26*	(7.45)

Notes: The table shows results from a fuzzy RD specification of field enrollment on average earnings (in inflation-adjusted kSEK) 10-14 years after treatment. Enrollment is interacted with an indicator variable for whether at least one of the parents has a degree in field j. The first set of columns shows returns to enrolling in a preferred field for individuals who do not have a parent with a degree in that field, while the second shows the interaction coefficients. The last row shows the pooled estimate across all fields. The sample is different from the main analysis and focuses on applications submitted before 2010.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

By field, we see large positive baseline returns for several of the most inherited fields, including business, law, technology, and medicine. This is consistent with the predicted earnings results in Table 6. But the interaction terms provide little evidence that children with same-field parents earn higher returns when they enroll in those fields. The negative pooled interaction corresponds to a 30% drop, and the field-specific interactions are noisy and mixed. Appendix Table C.4 does not materially strengthen the comparative-advantage interpretation: the interaction estimates for capital and self-employment income are also imprecise, with negative pooled interactions and mixed field-specific patterns. Taken together, these results are hard to square with parental field enrollment creating systematically higher labor market returns for children who follow their parents. The next section instead considers whether parents act as role models.

13. There are not nearly enough cases where both parent and child are quasi-randomly admitted to exploit both margins.

6.3 The parent as a role model

If following a parent does not systematically raise earnings returns, why do children do it? Another plausible explanation is that parents act as role models and make their field more salient and accessible. Role models have been shown to strongly influence education choices (Breda et al. 2023), and the educational sibling spillover effects in Altmejd et al. (2021) can likely be attributed to a similar mechanism. This interpretation also fits models in which children learn about field-specific ability from parental signals (Altonji et al. 2016; Proctor 2022). A parent's field may then look safer or easier to navigate because the child knows more about it ex ante.

One way to study role model effects is to look at field inheritance by gender. Research on educational role models often highlights the importance of self-identification (see e.g., Breda et al. 2023). Table 10 reports estimates of parental enrollment on child degree completion by the gender of parents and children. Again, the final row reports pooled estimates. The strongest aggregate effects run from fathers to sons, but mothers also exert a positive influence on both sons and daughters. The field-level patterns are mixed. Same-gender spillovers are stronger in some cases, like for business, but not in others. Still, some of the clearest estimates arise where parents go against gender stereotypes: fathers have especially large effects in humanities and, for daughters, in health, while mothers' effects are unusually strong in technology.

Table 10. Field inheritance and gender composition

Field	Father - Son		Father - Daughter		Mother - Son		Mother - Daughter	
Teaching	1.07	(1.71)	$4.06^{\dagger}$	(2.46)	0.75	(1.53)	1.65	(2.14)
Humanities	39.52^{**}	(13.29)	−0.41	(16.33)	−2.25	(4.40)	4.82	(5.80)
Business	5.02^{*}	(2.02)	2.90	(2.13)	−0.24	(1.95)	6.12^{**}	(2.11)
Law	3.47	(2.60)	−2.54	(3.25)	−1.13	(1.75)	0.73	(2.34)
Social science	−2.71	(2.84)	2.94	(3.62)	0.44	(2.19)	0.74	(2.79)
Natural science	−0.72	(3.06)	4.87	(3.12)	−2.82	(3.44)	−5.23	(3.68)
Technology	8.56^{**}	(2.66)	9.19^{***}	(2.32)	$5.81^{\dagger}$	(2.97)	10.27^{***}	(2.67)
Agriculture	$3.54^{\dagger}$	(1.98)	2.96	(1.88)	0.18	(1.32)	3.83	(2.44)
Medicine	4.19^{*}	(1.85)	6.07^{**}	(1.93)	2.58	(1.89)	5.45^{*}	(2.39)
Health	1.53	(2.66)	10.54^{*}	(4.38)	2.84	(1.91)	1.37	(3.06)
Services	15.61^{*}	(6.78)	−3.72	(4.30)	3.69	(4.75)	−1.31	(3.15)
Aggregate	6.18^{***}	(1.12)	$2.06^{\dagger}$	(1.15)	2.61^{*}	(1.06)	2.48^{*}	(1.18)

Notes: The table reports results from a regression where parent enrollment is interacted with field as well as parent and child gender. Each column shows linear combinations of baseline and interaction coefficients and stars indicate whether the linear combination is significantly different from zero. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3. For the raw interaction coefficients (and tests of difference between gender pairs), see Appendix Table C.5.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

A possible explanation for why the effect is often weaker for mothers, which is echoed in several of the cited studies, is that mothers less often pursue careers in occupations related to the field that they graduated from. A concern is thus that the effect for mothers mainly works through assortative mating, where mothers who enroll in a field become more likely to partner with someone from that field. It could then be the father's occupational influence that also drives the effect for mothers. Appendix Table C.7 does show strong same-field assortative mating, especially for mothers. At the same time, Table C.8 shows that fathers continue to influence their children's field choices even when the other parent does not

have a degree in the same field, and the corresponding point estimates for mothers remain positive in most specifications. Because partner choice is itself affected by treatment, these results should be interpreted cautiously.

Building on the results of Altmejd et al. (2021), parental influence should be strongest for the first-born child, who does not have any older siblings to follow. Appendix Table C.6 is consistent with this: the effects on ranks first and enrollment decline with birth order. The results for degree completion are unreliable because the outcome here only counts children following before the age of 30, to not give earlier born children a mechanical advantage.

The appendix contains additional analyses that qualify or reinforce the interpretation in this section. Table C.9 shows little systematic heterogeneity by grandparent education, and Table C.10 is more consistent with weaker transmission after retirement than with a fixed family-background explanation. Appendix Section D reports the corresponding results for narrow fields. Appendix Section E then shows that the main results are not simply inherited institutions or locations, and that the extensive margin of college-going appears much less important than the intensive margin of field choice.

7 Conclusion

Field of study is strongly persistent across generations: among university-educated families, the probability that a child graduates from a field is about twice as high when a parent holds a degree in that field. Using quasi-random variation in admission to Swedish university programs, I show that the direct causal effect is substantial, but only about half as large as the association.

The field of study choice of a parent strongly impacts the educational trajectory of their children. I have shown that the likelihood that a child graduates from a field increases by 3.3 percentage points, or 33% (2.2 percentage points, or 54% for narrow fields), if the parent enrolls in that field, when compared to parents who apply to the same field but then end up studying something else. The results are even larger when scaled by parental degree completion, and are robust to a large set of robustness and placebo checks.

Disaggregating the estimates by field shows substantial heterogeneity. Few point estimates are negative, but some fields are inherited much more strongly than others. Some of the more precisely estimated inherited fields also tend to have strong labor market prospects. Parental enrollment increases the probability that a child graduates in technology by 7.4 percentage points (36%), compared with an effect of -0.9 percentage points (-26%) in natural science. The gap between causal effects and descriptive associations also varies substantially across fields. In relative terms, the association in technology, 46%, is close to the causal effect of 49%, whereas in agriculture the association, 550%, is much larger than the causal effect of 128%.

These heterogeneous patterns likely reflect a complex set of differences in educational and occupational experiences across fields. There is roughly a 30-year gap between the university application of a parent and that of their child, so most children are not old enough to directly observe their parents' time at university. The analysis suggests field inheritance operates through parents' later labor market exposure and the information it provides. Table 5 shows that transmission is much weaker once we keep the field representativeness of the parent's job constant, and Table 6 indicates stronger transmission from fields with better predicted labor market outcomes.

Research on occupational inheritance often claims children follow their parents because they have a comparative advantage, either because of human capital transfers or nepotism. I evaluated this claim from two perspectives. First, using grade-9 test scores, Table 7 provides some evidence that parental field

enrollment improves related skills, especially along STEM-related margins. I then looked at labor market returns directly. Table 9 points away from comparative advantage: children who follow their parents do not earn higher returns, and if anything the pooled interaction implies about 30% lower returns. Comparative advantage is therefore hard to sustain as the main mechanism behind field inheritance.

The evidence is more consistent with an alternative mechanism. Like siblings (Altmejd et al. 2021), parents seem to act as role models, providing information and increasing the accessibility of their choices. This hypothesis is supported by Table 10, where the sample is split by the gender of parents and children. The strongest aggregate influence runs from fathers to sons, but mothers also matter, and some of the clearest field-level estimates arise when parents choose fields that are incongruent with gender stereotypes.

Field of study remains strongly persistent across generations, and this paper shows that the pattern does not simply reflect shared family background or broader social stratification. Parents' own educational choices also causally shape how their children later sort across fields. But the causal effect explains only part of the observed persistence, implying that field inheritance reflects both the consequences of parents' choices and broader social environments.

Parents shape children's field choices not mainly through comparative advantage, but by making particular educational and occupational paths more visible and easier to navigate. This broadens how we think about equality of opportunity in higher education. It is not only about who gets to university, but also about which fields students are exposed to and come to see as realistic options.

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Appendix

A The Swedish university application system

This section provides additional details about the Swedish higher education system and its centralized admission process. Much of the information is taken directly from application documents that have been archived at the Swedish National Archives. In addition, Riksrevisionen (2025) provides a recent overview of the system.

The university application data used in this paper comes from three different admission systems. The first system, A1, was in use between 1977 and 1992. It was replaced by the H97 system, used between 1993 and 2004. The applications and admission results from these systems were communicated using paper forms and regular mail. Applications submitted through these systems have been archived at the Swedish National Archives, from where they were retrieved for use in this paper. In 2005, the NyA system was introduced. NyA enabled online application and is still in use today. Application data from NyA was retrieved directly from the Swedish Council for Higher Education (UHR). Because of changes to archival laws, the first NyA years are not fully covered in the data used here. In practice, the direct UHR extract begins in 2008, with only partial information available for 2006 and 2007.

The A1 and H97 systems were not universally adopted. Applications to certain programs and institutions, like some health-related and artistic programs, were handled outside the centralized system. Only with the introduction of NyA did all admissions go through the centralized system. NyA also covers applications to individual courses and to advanced levels of education, while the previous systems only handled applications to introductory degree programs (although the current division into undergraduate and graduate programs was not really established until 2008, with the introduction of the Bologna system).

General eligibility ("allmän behörighet") for post-secondary education in Sweden requires completed upper secondary education. As a backup, the so-called 25:4 eligibility rule granted eligibility to those aged 25 or older with at least four years of labor market experience and sufficient knowledge of Swedish and English. The rule was removed in 2008.[14]. Certain programs also require passing grades in specific subjects ("särskild behörighet"). Engineering programs, for example, often require completion of specific science and math courses at the upper secondary level.

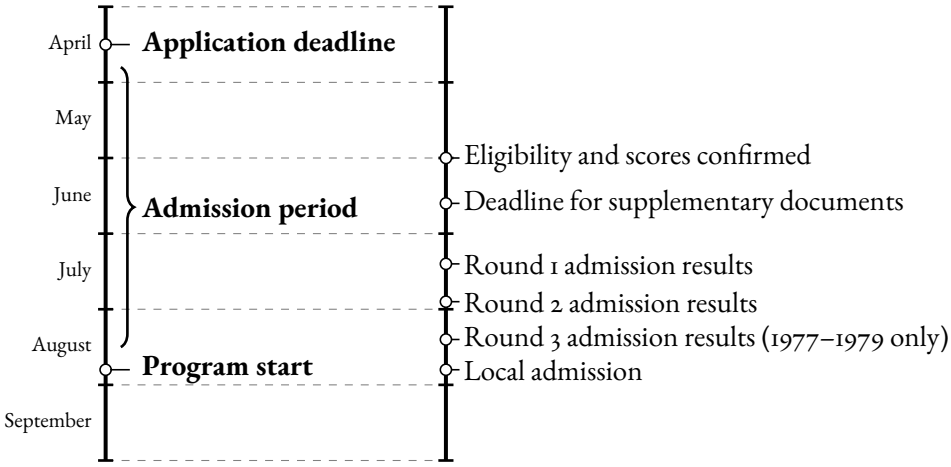
Students apply directly to programs and courses at the universities. The centralized admission process is described below. After admission, students enroll in courses that give academic credits. Course enrollment and completion is registered centrally to qualify students for stipends and financing, and recorded by SCB in *Högskoleregistret*. Programs are essentially packages of courses that award degrees upon completion. They often include a mix of mandatory and elective courses. At the end of their programs, students can apply for field-specific degrees. Degree requirements often include completing a certain number of credits in the subject and writing a thesis. Högskoleregistret also contains individual-level information on degree completion. Degrees can also be awarded to students who never apply to a specific program, but who complete the required courses through separate applications.

A.1 The admissions process

Applications through the centralized system are submitted during separate admission periods for each semester. A majority of programs start in the fall. Figure A.1 depicts the approximate timeline of a fall semester application. When applying, applicants submit ordered lists of up to 12 program-institution combinations. The number was increased to 20 with the introduction of NyA in 2005, mainly because applicants could now also rank individual courses in the same application.

14. Instead, individuals who did not fulfill eligibility requirements were required to supplement their education with adult education at the upper secondary level.

Figure A.1. Timeline of admission process (fall semester)



Notes: The figure outlines the admission process to Swedish higher education. Most programs start each year in the fall, but there is also a corresponding spring semester application period for courses and programs with a starting date in January. The application deadline for spring semester admissions is in mid October.

In the first response from the admissions agency, applicants get a confirmation letter documenting their eligibility status and the admission scores assigned to their applications.[15] Applicants can then request reevaluation and/or submit additional materials, like updated grades or other documents that were not available to them at the time of application. This commonly includes final grades from upper secondary school for those applying directly, and documentation of work experience during the final months of the spring semester.

The second response (in early July) includes admission decisions from the first admission round. Applicants are informed about which (if any) of the alternatives in their application they were admitted to. Applicants can only be admitted to one program, and all lower prioritized alternatives are discarded[16]. When applicants have higher prioritized alternatives for which they are eligible but where their score is below the cutoff, they are offered the possibility to queue for a spot to these alternatives. The admission results include information about their current position in the queue for these alternatives.

Then the process is repeated for a second admission round (and again for a third round for years 1977-1979). After the final round, applicants can at most accept and/or queue for two alternatives. An applicant who has been offered a spot for their third prioritized alternative but is waitlisted for their first and second can either queue for alternatives 1 and 2 or accept 3 and queue for one or the other. The programs start in late August, shortly after the final admission round. After this, there is a final opportunity for local admission. If an admitted applicant does not show up, each institution can contact those who decided to stay in the queue after the final round to offer them the spot. These local admissions are not included in the application data and thus do not influence the calculation of cutoffs. Local admissions are rare, because many institutions admit more students than they actually want to account for no-shows.

15. It is also at this stage that applicants get decisions on possible exceptions from eligibility and/or scoring, for example due to health or disability. There are very few such cases and they are not included in the analyses of this paper.

16. Starting in 2005, when applicants are allowed to mix applications to degree programs and courses, the rule is changed to a maximum of 45 ECTS per semester, meaning that an applicant could be admitted to both a full-time program and a part-time course at the same time.

A.2 Scoring

Applicants compete for admission in multiple *admission groups* with different scoring rules. These groups have changed substantially (and increased in number) over time, but some core principles have remained constant. There are two main scoring systems: one based on upper secondary school grades and one based on results from Högskoleprovet, a voluntary standardized university admissions test. Applicants automatically compete in all admission groups that they are eligible for (fulfill requirements for both *allmän* and *särskild* eligibility). GPA scores are based on a fixed number of upper secondary credits, and always include the upper secondary courses required for eligibility. Since *särskild* eligibility often varies between programs in different fields, an applicant who completed more upper secondary credits than required could have their grades scored differently by program despite competing in the same admission group.

Applicants normally have a clear understanding of which groups they belong to and what their score is in each group already when they apply, but they are also informed about their scores in the first letter received from the admissions agency and given the chance to supplement their application and/or dispute their eligibility/scoring.

Table A.1. Admission groups fall 1981

Group	Spots	Scoring	Max score	N admitted
1A	30%	3/4-year upper secondary GPA	5.0	3176
1B	70%	+ experience	7.5	7566
2A	30%	2-year upper secondary (vocational) GPA	5.0	1058
2B	70%	+ experience	7.5	2438
3		Folkhögskola GPA	6.5	494
4A	50%	Högskoleprovet + experience (4A only)	4.5	902
4B	50%	Högskoleprovet + experience (all)	4.5	698
5		Foreign applicants	N/A	-

Notes: Experience refers to documented work and organizational experience. Folkhögskola is a type of adult education. Högskoleprovet is a voluntary standardized test used for university admission. 4A includes those who only compete in group 4 while 4B also includes those who compete in other groups. Spots are divided in proportion to the number of eligible applicants and then allocated between subgroups based on the percentages reported. All individuals in groups 1 and 2 compete in both subgroups.

In the 1977–1992 period, used for identification in this paper, there were a total of 21 different admission groups, but no more than 8 in any given year. Table A.1 lists the admission groups for the fall semester of 1981 as an example. Spots were assigned to each of the groups proportional to the number of eligible applicants. Applicants competing in groups 1 and 2 all competed both with (subgroups B, 70% of spots, filled first) and without (subgroups A, 30% of spots for remaining applicants) documented extracurricular experience. Work experience awarded at most 2 points and was counted as 0.1 point per 3 months of full-time employment. An additional 0.5/1 points were given for 2/4 years of documented organizational work, like in a union or a political party. In total, work and organizational experience could award no more than 2.5 points. If an applicant did not supply any documentation of work experience, their score in groups A and B was equal, solely based on their GPA. Group 3 was for applicants with grades from a Folkhögskola, a type of adult education. Group 4 was mainly for those who are not eligible to compete in the other groups. This includes applicants who get eligibility through the 25:4 rule (being at least 25 years old and having at least 4 years of work experience), but also those with GPA from

older grading systems. Scoring is based on a combination of Högskoleprovet score and experience, and is split in half: one group for applicants not competing in any other group (4A) and one for those who also compete in other groups (4B). Finally, group 5 includes foreign applicants judged on a case-by-case basis with no scoring.

Admission groups only changed slightly from the example above during the RDD sample period of 1977-1992. Changes include allowing applicants to compete in group 1A and 2A only for the first three years after graduating upper secondary school (1982). Starting in 1984, grades from subjects required for eligibility counted higher, which meant that applicant scores in a given admission group could vary between programs.

The application system was revamped in 1993 and again in 2005. These changes brought substantial modifications to admission groups, although the core of separately competing with upper secondary school GPA and Högskoleprovet remained. The 1993–2005 period had similar structure to the earlier period but with different names. After 2005, the number and types of admission groups increased substantially. Since the NyA system is also used for applications to advanced courses and programs, admission groups based on academic credits were introduced. Starting in 2008, work experience was no longer awarded bonus points at the introductory level. Furthermore, there were several changes to the upper secondary school grading system during this period, with new admission groups being created to handle applicants with grades from different systems.

Also, the number of spots reserved for each admission group, and the rules for how these are set, varies over institutions and time. As a general rule, the number of spots is proportional to the number of applicants eligible to compete in a given admission group. Before proportional allocation, certain categories of groups were given fixed shares. During the 1977-1992 period no more than 10% of spots could be reserved for foreign applicants, and the division between groups 1A/B and 2A/B was set to 30/70%, while it was 50/50% between 4A and 4B. The current system was put in place in 1998, when the law was changed to reserve a third of spots for admission by upper secondary school GPA, another third for Högskoleprovet and work experience, and the last third to be decided by the institutions themselves. This last third of spots allowed institutions to admit using alternative rules like interviews and tests, but a large majority of introductory programs ended up allocating also these spots by GPA. Until 2008, applicants competing with Högskoleprovet could do so both with and without work experience, with half of the spots reserved for each group. The possible extra credits for work experience were removed in 2008. Among GPA-based groups, the number of spots reserved for each subgroup was (and still is) proportional to the number of applicants.

A.3 The admission algorithm

During each admission round an algorithm is run to decide who is admitted to each alternative. There is very little documentation available on the exact workings of this algorithm, but a court case from 2009 (*T 3897-08* 2009) provides a detailed description of how the algorithm worked in the H97 system, in place during 1993–2005. The cursory descriptions provided for applicants during the earlier A1 system (1977–1992) provide no reason to believe that the implementation for this period differed in any substantial way. While the current system is more complicated, representatives from the admissions agency have confirmed that the relevant workings of the algorithm have remained the same[17].

Each application period consists of two or three rounds. During each round, an allocation mechanism admits students to alternatives until either all spots have been filled or all applicants have been

17. Personal communication with representatives from the Swedish Council for Higher Education (UHR), September 2017.

admitted. Applicants are ranked by score in every admission group that they are eligible for and then admitted sequentially until all spots are filled. The number of spots for each group is fixed (see above). With some exceptions the next spot to be filled is from the group with the largest number of unfilled spots.[18] An applicant who is admitted in one group is removed from the queue in all other groups. After all slots are filled to every alternative (or no more applicants remain) some applicants will have been admitted to multiple alternatives. They are then assigned to their highest prioritized alternative and removed from all lower ranked. This opens up spots, and the next applicant in line is admitted. The process is repeated until no more spots open up, ending the admission round.

After the admission round is finished, offers are sent out. Applicants then decide whether to accept their offers and/or if they want to stay on the waiting list for admission to higher prioritized alternatives. The admission procedure is then repeated in a second and, for 1977-1979, third admission round.

Disregarding the priority-rank tie breaking mechanisms described below, this algorithm is a truncated multicategory serial dictatorship, a mechanism that is not strategy-proof but still minimally manipulable (Balinski and Sönmez 1999; Pathak and Sönmez 2013). Applicants are incentivized to think strategically about their final rankings, and to include safe options over higher preferred ones if they max out their application list.

A.4 Tie-breaking

As described in the main text, the fact that scores are coarse means that there are often ties at the cutoff. When fewer spots remain than there are applicants with the same score, some will be admitted while others will not. The algorithm breaks such ties already when ranking all eligible applicants in each admission group. The methods for tie-breaking have changed over time. During all of 1977–2005, applicants with identical scores were prioritized based on the rank of the choice in their application list. This was official policy until 1992, when a new Higher Education Ordinance law (1993:100) was passed that did not mention priority-based tie-breaking. However, an inquiry found that priority-based tie-breaking had continued mistakenly (Association of Swedish Higher Education 2002), simply because the programming had not been updated. It was not removed until the system was overhauled in 2005.

With the new law of 1993, a new tie-breaking mechanism was introduced. Applicants from an underrepresented gender were supposed to be prioritized among those with equal scores. Between 1993 and 1998 a gender was considered underrepresented if it made up 30% or less of the applicants to that program. From 1998 to 2005, this threshold was increased to 40%. Only if the share of applicants from one gender was below these levels did any tie-breaking by gender take place. The order of tie-breaking varied between programs and years, perhaps because priority-based tie-breaking was not officially in use during this period. In 2006, the law mandating that preference be given to the underrepresented gender was reinterpreted as requiring a weighted lottery. The likelihood that a given position among tied applicants was assigned to a specific gender was proportional to the inverse of that gender's share of applicants. If 80% of applicants were men, a woman and a man with the same score would be ranked in favor of the woman with 80% probability. This changed again in 2008, when each gender was given alternating priority among tied applicants. Finally, in 2010 a supreme court ruling found the use of gender-based tie-breaking to be unconstitutional, and the practice was removed completely. Around the same time, the use of Högskoleprovet scores was introduced as a way to break ties.

18. During the 1977–1992 period, all applicants in groups 1 and 2 competed in both subgroups A and B. They were first admitted in groups B (70% of spots, counting experience), and only the remaining applicants were ranked and admitted based on GPA only (30% of spots). To square this with the described process, the algorithm would treat 1A and 1B as one admission group with a fixed number of spots, first using the B part of the group and then the A part whenever a spot was allocated.

Any remaining ties were broken by lottery. Each applicant is given a random number, and when ranked this number is used as the final sorting criterion. I have access to these lottery numbers for the 1977–1992 period and again for (parts of) 2008–2018. While not available for the other years, admission outcomes at the cutoff are consistent with the use of random numbers as final tie-breakers throughout the entire sample period.

B Additional robustness checks

This section includes additional robustness and validation exercises. First, Table B.1 shows balance tests for characteristics defined after treatment, focusing on enrollment timing and fertility-related outcomes. Threshold-crossing clearly hastens enrollment, and to a lesser extent degree completion, but there is little evidence that it changes whether applicants have children or whether they satisfy the "Child born before 2002" restriction used to define the study sample. The jointly estimated specifications allow for small shifts in family size and timing, but these are economically minor relative to the main effects on educational timing.

Table B.1. Post-treatment timing and downstream outcomes

	Separately estimated	Jointly estimated
Age at first enrollment	−0.003***	−0.004***
	(0.000)	(0.000)
Age at first degree	−0.001***	0.000
	(0.000)	(0.000)
Parent has at least one child	0.000	
	(0.002)	
Child born before 2002	−0.001	
	(0.002)	
Number of children	0.000	−0.002
	(0.001)	(0.001)
Age at first child	0.000	0.000
	(0.000)	(0.000)
Age at first job	0.001**	0.003***
	(0.000)	(0.000)
Child applies to university	0.000	−0.001
	(0.002)	(0.002)
Observations		262,524
Wald statistic		16.354
		[p=0]

Notes: The table shows balance tests for characteristics defined after treatment. The left column reports coefficients from regressions where threshold-crossing is regressed on each covariate separately, while the right column reports jointly estimated coefficients. The regressions are run on the full sample of applicants within the 2 std. bandwidth, including those with no children.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table B.2 reports first stage estimates for the placebo analysis of the effect of child threshold-crossing on parental education in Table 4. These first stages are strong and of similar order of magnitude as those reported in Table C.1, ensuring that the placebo design is technically comparable to the main one.

Next, Figure B.1 reports the main estimation using various alternative cutoffs. For most outcomes, the estimated effects disappear as soon as the cutoff is moved away from its true position. These results further strengthen the credibility of the RDD analysis.

The fourth display, Table B.3, shows the main results with quadratic slopes of the running variable included separately for each admission group. The sign pattern and broad magnitudes remain similar to the baseline results, but precision falls noticeably in several columns.

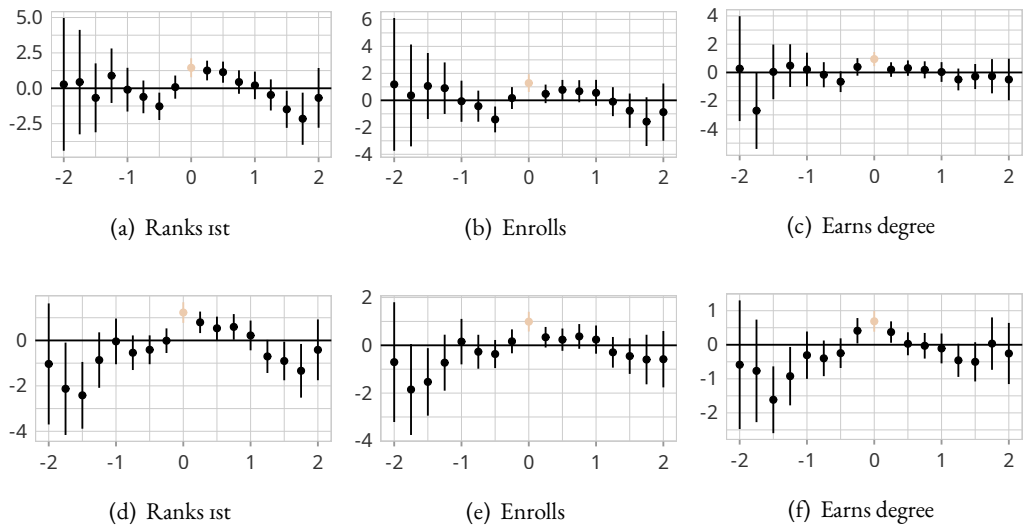
Table B.2. Placebo first stages

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Admitted	Enrolls	Graduates	Admitted	Enrolls	Graduates
Child above cutoff	70.70***	27.60***	23.10***	73.54***	38.55***	20.21***
	(0.31)	(0.45)	(0.47)	(0.27)	(0.39)	(0.39)
Observations	235,965	235,965	235,965	281,964	281,964	281,964
Control group mean	0%	38.4%	24.51%	0%	23.33%	16.62%

Notes: The table reports first stage estimates for the placebo analysis in Table 4.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Figure B.1. Placebo cutoffs



(a) Ranks 1st (b) Enrolls (c) Earns degree

(d) Ranks 1st (e) Enrolls (f) Earns degree

Notes: The plot shows the reduced form effects of the main analysis while the cutoff is changed away from its true position. At $x = -1$ for example, applicants with running variables lower than -1 are counted as below the cutoff, while those with scores at or above -1 are counted as above.

Fixed effects for the preferred and next-best field are included in all specifications to account for selection into different fields. A potential worry is that additional problematic selection happens within fields between programs. While still collapsing alternatives into broad and narrow fields, Table B.4 instead includes fixed effects for each cutoff.

Estimating separate slopes for the running variable per admission group accounts for variation in scoring policies. However, it means the main specification is pooling variation across multiple different quasi-experiments when fitting these lines. Table B.5 instead fits separate slopes below and above each cutoff. This exercise is very taxing on statistical power, and the estimation suffers from convergence problems, but the reported point estimates remain positive and often economically sizeable despite the loss of precision.

As discussed in Section 2, a tie-breaking mechanism prioritizing those applicants who have ranked the alternative the highest could be a threat to the monotonicity assumption if applicants include safe

Table B.3. Quadratic running variable polynomials

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	1.03^{*}	1.37^{**}	0.92^{*}	1.07^{**}	0.87^{**}	0.66^{**}
	(0.48)	(0.47)	(0.36)	(0.33)	(0.31)	(0.23)
Parent enrolls in j	4.73^{*}	6.28^{**}	4.20^{*}	4.59^{**}	3.74^{**}	2.83^{**}
	(2.19)	(2.16)	(1.64)	(1.43)	(1.31)	(0.97)
Parent receives degree in j	6.29^{*}	8.34^{**}	5.58^{*}	6.04^{**}	4.91^{**}	3.72^{**}
	(2.91)	(2.86)	(2.18)	(1.87)	(1.72)	(1.27)
Observations	223,670	223,670	223,670	255,961	255,961	255,961
Control group mean	21.72%	20.48%	10.12%	9.74%	7.41%	4.18%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	1176	1176	1176	1669	1669	1669
1st stage Wald (degree)	629	629	629	897	897	897

Notes: The admission group polynomials included in the main analysis are here estimated with both linear and quadratic terms. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table B.4. Cutoff fixed effects

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	1.33^{***}	1.10^{**}	0.80^{**}	1.30^{***}	0.92^{***}	0.69^{***}
	(0.37)	(0.36)	(0.28)	(0.26)	(0.23)	(0.17)
Parent enrolls in j	4.90^{***}	4.08^{**}	2.96^{**}	4.46^{***}	3.15^{***}	2.36^{***}
	(1.36)	(1.34)	(1.02)	(0.87)	(0.80)	(0.59)
Parent receives degree in j	6.74^{***}	5.61^{**}	4.06^{**}	5.86^{***}	4.15^{***}	3.10^{***}
	(1.87)	(1.84)	(1.40)	(1.15)	(1.05)	(0.78)
Observations	223,670	223,670	223,670	255,961	255,961	255,961
Control group mean	21.72%	20.48%	10.12%	9.74%	7.41%	4.18%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	3060	3060	3060	4431	4431	4431
1st stage Wald (degree)	1526	1526	1526	2382	2382	2382

Notes: The table shows the same results as in Table 3 but with fixed effects for each cutoff instead of each field. Field-level fixed effects for the next-best field are still used.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table B.5. Separate slopes for each cutoff

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	1.05*	0.86†	0.65†	1.17***	0.68*	0.59*
	(0.49)	(0.48)	(0.37)	(0.34)	(0.32)	(0.24)
Parent enrolls in j	4.09*	3.36†	2.53†	4.15***	2.42*	2.10*
	(1.89)	(1.86)	(1.43)	(1.22)	(1.13)	(0.84)
Parent receives degree in j	5.46*	4.49†	3.38†	5.35***	3.12*	2.71*
	(2.52)	(2.48)	(1.90)	(1.57)	(1.45)	(1.08)
Observations	223,670	223,670	223,670	255,961	255,961	255,961
Control group mean	21.72%	20.48%	10.12%	9.74%	7.41%	4.18%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	1584	1584	1584	2508	2508	2508
1st stage Wald (degree)	829	829	829	1377	1377	1377

Notes: The table shows the same results as in Table 3 but with distinct linear fits of the running variable above and below each cutoff.
† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

options relatively high in their ranking. Since I remove dominated options when selecting field pairs, a more preferred field that is included below a safe option will rarely be included as k. I run a number of robustness checks to ensure this potential threat to the monotonicity assumption does not have any significant bearing on the results.

First, Table B.6 reports results where only applications with j as the highest ranked field have been included. Clearly, the applicant has no reason to rank a less preferred field first. The estimates remain positive, but several of the broad-field columns become smaller and less precise in this restricted sample.

Second, Table B.7 removes all applicants exactly at the cutoff from the analysis. In the main analysis, I use the predefined tie-breaking rules (including lottery numbers) to predict admission among applicants at the cutoff. The results in Table B.7 remain qualitatively similar to the main estimates, although some broad-field point estimates become somewhat larger.

Third, Table B.8 drops all cutoffs where the maximal attainable score in the admission group was required for admission. These cutoffs are special since all admissions are determined by the tie-breaking mechanism. The results are again very similar to the main findings.

To ease interpretation, the RDD specification used in this paper gives equal weights to observations irrespective of their distance to the cutoff. This relies on the bandwidth and admission group slopes to account for bias. Table B.9 shows that using triangular weights, and relying more on observations closer to the cutoff, matters little for aggregate estimates.

Table B.6. Only first-ranked j

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	1.10^{**}	$0.71^{\dagger}$	0.83^{**}	1.45^{***}	1.13^{***}	0.80^{***}
	(0.39)	(0.38)	(0.29)	(0.28)	(0.25)	(0.19)
Parent enrolls in j	3.77^{**}	$2.44^{\dagger}$	2.83^{**}	4.51^{***}	3.51^{***}	2.50^{***}
	(1.33)	(1.31)	(1.00)	(0.86)	(0.78)	(0.58)
Parent receives degree in j	5.09^{**}	$3.30^{\dagger}$	3.83^{**}	5.74^{***}	4.47^{***}	3.18^{***}
	(1.80)	(1.77)	(1.35)	(1.09)	(0.99)	(0.74)
Observations	160,829	160,829	160,829	180,500	180,500	180,500
Control group mean	22.18%	20.61%	10.43%	10.62%	7.97%	4.58%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	3215	3215	3215	4429	4429	4429
1st stage Wald (degree)	1581	1581	1581	2547	2547	2547

Notes: The sample includes observations where the preferred alternative j is ranked highest in the parent's application. There are no strategic incentives to rank anything but the most preferred alternative first. Coefficients and standard errors are reported in percentage points. All regressions use a bandwidth of 2 std, a uniform kernel, and include separate slopes by admission group score, above and below the cutoff. Fixed-effects for preferred and next-best field, semester, priority rank, and gender are also included. Standard errors are clustered at the family level.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table B.7. Donut

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	1.72^{***}	1.46^{***}	1.03^{***}	1.12^{***}	0.92^{***}	0.74^{***}
	(0.42)	(0.41)	(0.31)	(0.28)	(0.26)	(0.19)
Parent enrolls in j	6.00^{***}	5.10^{***}	3.59^{***}	3.59^{***}	2.95^{***}	2.40^{***}
	(1.46)	(1.43)	(1.08)	(0.90)	(0.82)	(0.61)
Parent receives degree in j	8.36^{***}	7.10^{***}	5.00^{***}	4.73^{***}	3.89^{***}	3.16^{***}
	(2.03)	(1.99)	(1.51)	(1.18)	(1.08)	(0.80)
Observations	196,043	196,043	196,043	223,100	223,100	223,100
Control group mean	21.47%	20.21%	9.98%	9.63%	7.29%	4.12%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	2670	2670	2670	3769	3769	3769
1st stage Wald (degree)	1283	1283	1283	2096	2096	2096

Notes: In this table, the main estimation is run on a sample where applicants who are exactly at the cutoff are excluded. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table B.8. Excluding perfect score cutoffs

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	1.40***	1.24***	0.92***	1.21***	0.96***	0.68***
	(0.35)	(0.35)	(0.26)	(0.23)	(0.21)	(0.16)
Parent enrolls in j	4.94***	4.38***	3.24***	3.98***	3.14***	2.22***
	(1.23)	(1.22)	(0.92)	(0.77)	(0.70)	(0.51)
Parent receives degree in j	7.00***	6.20***	4.59***	5.30***	4.18***	2.96***
	(1.74)	(1.72)	(1.30)	(1.02)	(0.93)	(0.68)
Observations	214,725	214,725	214,725	246,883	246,883	246,883
Control group mean	21.72%	20.64%	10.12%	9.59%	7.34%	4.08%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	3583	3583	3583	4982	4982	4982
1st stage Wald (degree)	1702	1702	1702	2743	2743	2743

Notes: In this table, the main estimation is run on a sample where those cutoffs that required a perfect score for admission have been excluded. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table B.9. Triangular kernel

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	1.26***	1.25***	0.94***	1.15***	0.98***	0.66***
	(0.36)	(0.35)	(0.27)	(0.25)	(0.22)	(0.16)
Parent enrolls in j	4.76***	4.71***	3.53***	4.05***	3.44***	2.32***
	(1.35)	(1.33)	(1.00)	(0.86)	(0.78)	(0.58)
Parent receives degree in j	6.60***	6.54***	4.90***	5.34***	4.54***	3.07***
	(1.87)	(1.84)	(1.39)	(1.14)	(1.03)	(0.76)
Observations	224,810	224,810	224,810	256,941	256,941	256,941
Control group mean	22.23%	21.05%	10.41%	10.11%	7.73%	4.34%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	2926	2926	2926	3986	3986	3986
1st stage Wald (degree)	1438	1438	1438	2220	2220	2220

Notes: The table shows the same results as in Table 3 but with observations weighted by a triangular kernel.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

C Additional results

This section reports additional results and further subgroup analyses. To begin, Table C.1 reports the first stage regressions also presented in Figure 4.

Table C.1. First stage estimates

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Admitted	Enrolls	Graduates	Admitted	Enrolls	Graduates
Above cutoff	72.40***	28.66***	20.61***	73.34***	30.70***	23.29***
	(0.32)	(0.46)	(0.47)	(0.29)	(0.42)	(0.43)
Observations	111,330	111,330	111,330	127,610	127,610	127,610
Control group mean	0%	29.96%	22.76%	0%	23.54%	18.88%

Notes: Observations are not repeated for each child. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Figure C.1 reports RD-plots for the three outcome variables: (1) if the child ranks field j first in an application to university, (2) if they enroll in j, and (3) if they earn a degree from j, for broad and narrow fields respectively. The observations are grouped in equally sized bins and plotted as functions of the running variable, demeaned for each cutoff. Inside each plot, the reduced form regression coefficients from Table 3 are reported. These are the baseline reduced form estimates, using the same uniform-kernel specification and separate controls of the running variable on each side of the threshold for each admission group.

Next, Table C.2 reports the by-field estimates from the main specification plotted in Figure 5. Table C.3 instead compares the OLS associations with the causal IV estimates, both based on parental degree completion to maximize comparability. Corresponding tables for narrow fields are Table D.2 and Table D.3.

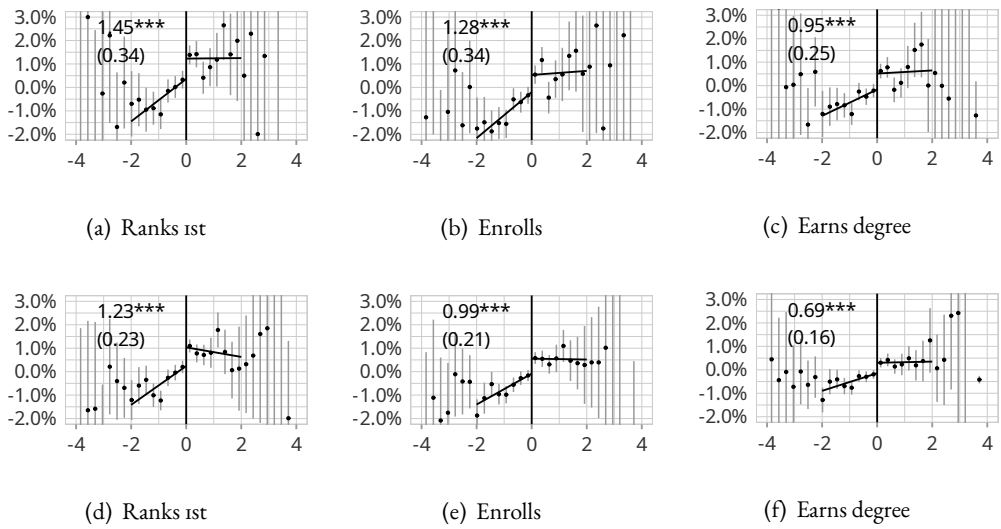
Table C.2. Main estimates by field

Field	Ranks 1st			Enrolls			Graduates		
Teaching	3.36*	(1.68)	26%	1.53	(1.65)	12%	1.60	(1.22)	26%
Humanities	11.67†	(6.63)	34%	14.23*	(6.85)	37%	5.69	(3.60)	88%
Business	3.23†	(1.68)	11%	1.91	(1.64)	7%	3.41**	(1.24)	27%
Law	7.03**	(2.26)	45%	5.42*	(2.20)	37%	0.34	(1.36)	8%
Social science	3.06	(2.28)	10%	3.91†	(2.25)	13%	0.03	(1.58)	0%
Natural science	4.35	(3.19)	36%	3.99	(3.98)	18%	−0.88	(1.91)	−26%
Technology	9.02***	(1.84)	25%	10.43***	(1.87)	28%	7.44***	(1.52)	36%
Agriculture	3.06†	(1.61)	47%	3.40*	(1.54)	71%	2.57*	(1.10)	107%
Medicine	8.50***	(1.72)	52%	5.55***	(1.45)	55%	4.45***	(1.11)	69%
Health	1.48	(2.20)	9%	1.22	(2.09)	9%	2.52	(1.76)	23%
Services	−1.50	(2.70)	−27%	−0.68	(3.06)	−12%	1.77	(2.44)	48%
Aggregate	5.06***	(1.19)	23%	4.46***	(1.17)	22%	3.30***	(0.89)	33%

Notes: The table reports the estimates from Figure 5 with relative effects (third column in each outcome group) compared to the control group means.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Figure C.1. Regression discontinuity plots



(a) Ranks 1st (b) Enrolls (c) Earns degree

(d) Ranks 1st (e) Enrolls (f) Earns degree

Notes: The plots show the demeaned share of children following their parents above and below the cutoff. The outcome variables have been demeaned using the same set of fixed effects as in the main specification. Slopes of the running variable, fitted with a uniform kernel on observations within two standard deviations from the cutoff, are included. Applicants with a score exactly at the cutoff but where a tie-breaking mechanism has ensured they are not admitted have been included in the bin below the cutoff. Inside the plot, coefficients from Table 3 are reported. These are fitted allowing the slope of the running variable to vary also for each admission group.

University programs vary in their popularity and selectivity, meaning that some fields will have applicants of higher ability. Figure C.3 shows average upper secondary school GPA of enrollees and cutoffs (standardized by admission group) separately for each field of study. There is substantial variation in both across and within fields. Table 6 uses this variation to evaluate if inheritance effects vary by the quality of the programs.

Next, Table C.7 shows how the likelihood of the other parent also having a degree in j is affected by enrollment. Not only do we observe strong assortative mating, the effect is much larger for mothers. Table C.8 runs the inheritance regression but with an interaction for if the partner's degree is in the same field. We see stronger inheritance for these cases, but no clear indication this mechanism is gendered. Of course, partner choice is affected by treatment and adding it to the right-hand side of the regression could introduce endogeneity. These results should be interpreted with caution.

Table C.9 reports the results split by the education level of the grandparents, with little systematic difference across strata.

Table C.10 shows inheritance by the age of the parent at the time the child is 18. While effects are imprecise, the estimates are much smaller and often negative among parents aged 65 and above.

Table C.3. Associations and causal effects

Field	Causal effect			OLS association		
Teaching	2.18	(1.58)	36%	3.12***	(0.05)	105%
Humanities	13.75	(8.58)	212%	2.89***	(0.09)	98%
Business	5.23**	(1.88)	41%	2.93***	(0.08)	51%
Law	0.70	(2.01)	16%	3.05***	(0.13)	191%
Social science	0.20	(3.08)	2%	1.68***	(0.10)	31%
Natural science	−1.08	(2.99)	−32%	1.35***	(0.08)	102%
Technology	10.21***	(2.08)	49%	4.30***	(0.09)	46%
Agriculture	3.07*	(1.27)	128%	2.19***	(0.12)	550%
Medicine	4.82***	(1.18)	75%	6.07***	(0.15)	577%
Health	3.15	(2.12)	29%	3.62***	(0.06)	65%
Services	2.45	(3.07)	66%	0.50***	(0.07)	19%
Aggregate	4.59***	(1.23)	45%	3.05***	(0.03)	89%

Notes: The "OLS association" column reports the diagonal of Figure 1: the OLS coefficient from regressing an indicator for the child holding a degree in the parent's field on an indicator for the parent holding that degree, estimated on degree-holding parents. The "Causal effect" column reports the corresponding IV estimate of parental degree completion on child degree completion from the RD design. In both columns, absolute effects are in percentage points and relative effects express the absolute effect as a percentage of the respective baseline rate (applicants below the cutoff for RD and parents with degrees in other fields for OLS).

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

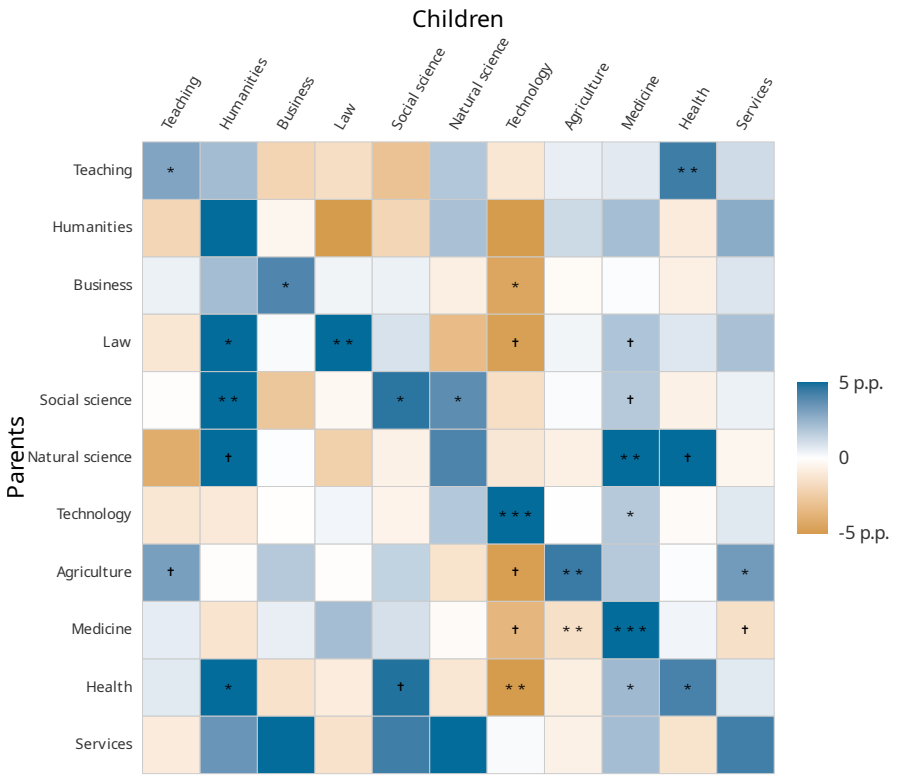
Table C.4. Returns to fields of study by parental degree (capital and self-employment income)

	Capital income				Self-employment income			
Field			× parent				× parent	
Teaching	−6.21	(13.40)	−2.40	(9.32)	7.63*	(3.73)	−7.18†	(4.11)
Humanities	9.80	(22.69)	−36.23	(31.13)	11.08	(7.64)	−9.71	(16.28)
Business	30.29	(20.96)	−34.74	(34.79)	−1.04	(1.64)	3.58	(2.27)
Law	−11.70	(12.26)	36.85	(37.19)	−0.17	(1.51)	1.48	(4.53)
Social science	−6.54	(19.36)	16.77	(60.77)	3.65	(2.57)	−0.46	(4.50)
Natural science	29.27	(26.79)	−43.12	(35.13)	4.23	(4.62)	−8.11	(10.49)
Technology	−16.48	(18.71)	41.21†	(21.67)	−1.78	(1.77)	−4.88†	(2.81)
Agriculture	−6.22	(9.73)	4.36	(13.08)	4.79*	(2.31)	7.73	(7.21)
Medicine	−3.89	(8.79)	0.48	(67.53)	−3.44**	(1.09)	1.43	(1.57)
Health	−23.19	(29.74)	26.38	(25.59)	−0.73	(2.12)	−2.73	(2.27)
Services	−12.31	(16.59)	−12.50	(24.02)	5.01	(4.50)	1.28	(9.94)
Aggregate	1.24	(11.96)	−0.34	(13.08)	0.12	(1.05)	−1.10	(0.96)

Notes: The table extends Table 9 to investigate if any potential returns from parental resources are earned through capital or self-employment income. This could be the case if children e.g. inherit the family business. Income is measured in inflation-adjusted kSEK.

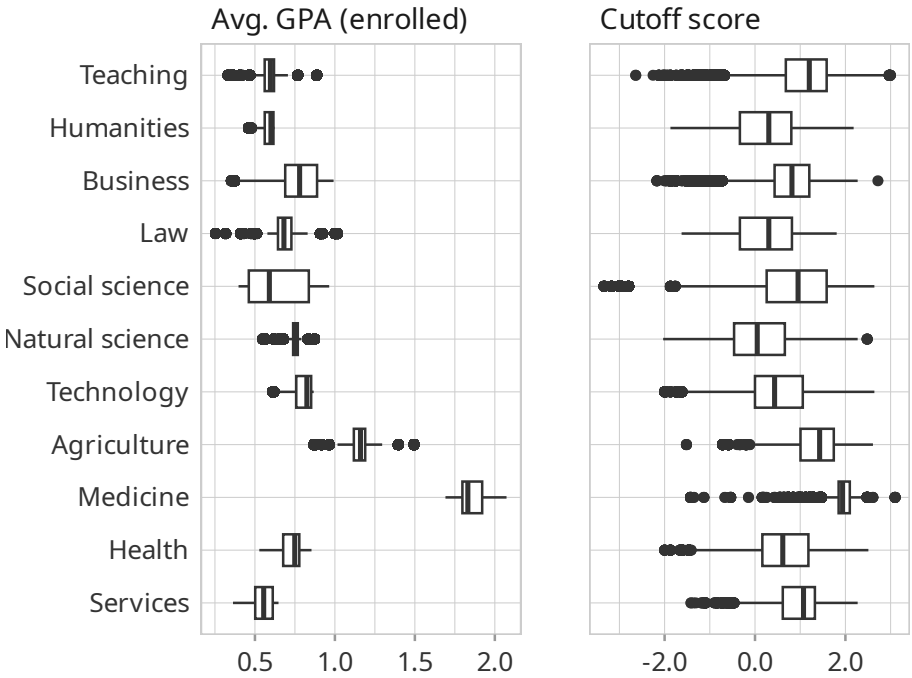
† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Figure C.2. Cross-field inheritance matrix (parent enrollment on child enrollment)



Notes: The matrix reports regression coefficients of parental field enrollment on child field enrollment. Figure 6 reports the corresponding effect on child degree completion. Estimation is done using the same setup as in Table 3. The colors are capped at effect sizes between -3 and 3 percentage points, since outliers (usually field combinations with few observations) would otherwise cause most cells to be indistinguishable from zero. Significance levels are not corrected for multiple comparisons. $+\ p \leq 0.1$, $*\ p \leq 0.05$, $**\ p \leq 0.01$, $***\ p \leq 0.001$.

Figure C.3. Field performance levels



Notes: The figure shows box plots of average upper secondary school GPA of enrollees (left) and cutoffs (right, standardized by admission group) separately for each field of study.

Table C.5. Field inheritance by gender (interaction effects)

	Baseline effect		Interactions					
Field	Graduates		× Daughter		× Mother		× Mother × Daughter	
Teaching	1.07	(1.71)	2.99	(2.76)	−0.32	(2.00)	−2.08	(3.56)
Humanities	39.52**	(13.29)	−39.93†	(20.55)	−41.77**	(13.90)	47.00*	(21.71)
Business	5.02*	(2.02)	−2.12	(2.68)	−5.27*	(2.58)	8.49*	(3.70)
Law	3.47	(2.60)	−6.01	(3.93)	−4.60	(2.86)	7.86†	(4.77)
Social science	−2.71	(2.84)	5.65	(4.43)	3.15	(3.37)	−5.35	(5.45)
Natural science	−0.72	(3.06)	5.59	(4.12)	−2.10	(4.47)	−7.99	(6.32)
Technology	8.56**	(2.66)	0.63	(3.21)	−2.75	(3.77)	3.83	(4.91)
Agriculture	3.54†	(1.98)	−0.58	(2.55)	−3.36	(2.20)	4.23	(3.71)
Medicine	4.19*	(1.85)	1.87	(2.50)	−1.62	(2.54)	1.00	(3.87)
Health	1.53	(2.66)	9.01†	(4.79)	1.31	(2.96)	−10.48†	(5.74)
Services	15.61*	(6.78)	−19.33*	(7.99)	−11.92	(8.07)	14.32	(9.62)
Aggregate	6.18***	(1.12)	−4.12***	(1.17)	−3.57**	(1.09)	3.98*	(1.56)

Notes: The table reports the baseline and interaction coefficients upon which Table 10 is based.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table C.6. Field inheritance by child birth order

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent enrolls in j	4.59***	4.16***	−0.37	3.13***	2.20***	−0.13
	(1.10)	(0.97)	(0.40)	(0.66)	(0.53)	(0.22)
× Second-born child	−3.54***	−3.49***	−0.52†	−2.72***	−1.98***	0.00
	(0.79)	(0.70)	(0.29)	(0.51)	(0.41)	(0.17)
× Third-born child	−5.40***	−4.83***	−0.90**	−3.24***	−2.60***	−0.04
	(0.96)	(0.84)	(0.31)	(0.60)	(0.47)	(0.17)
× ≥ Fourth-born child	−5.57***	−4.16**	−0.32	−3.43**	−2.07**	0.39
	(1.58)	(1.42)	(0.49)	(1.14)	(0.78)	(0.30)
Second-born child	−3.18***	−2.72***	−0.99***	−1.45***	−1.19***	−0.56***
	(0.40)	(0.35)	(0.15)	(0.23)	(0.18)	(0.08)
Third-born child	−5.48***	−4.69***	−1.19***	−2.49***	−1.62***	−0.69***
	(0.48)	(0.42)	(0.17)	(0.27)	(0.21)	(0.08)
≥ Fourth-born child	−6.04***	−5.46***	−1.62***	−2.74***	−2.03***	−0.83***
	(0.85)	(0.74)	(0.22)	(0.59)	(0.34)	(0.10)
Observations	212,991	212,991	212,991	244,208	244,208	244,208
Control group mean	10.46%	7.87%	1.34%	4.76%	2.87%	0.55%
1st stage Wald	845	845	845	1169	1169	1169

Notes: The estimation excludes families with only one child. In addition, to not give earlier-born children a longer time (before measurement ends in 2023) to follow their parents, the outcome variables have been redefined to include only cases where the child follows within 30 years of treatment. Many children will not have earned degrees within this time period which is why the estimates and control group means for degree completion are so small. The reference group is firstborn children. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table C.7. Assortative mating

	Broad fields	Narrow fields
	Other parent has degree in j	Other parent has degree in j
Parent enrolls in j	8.44***	8.11***
	(1.44)	(0.97)
× Parent female	9.36***	7.74***
	(1.24)	(0.91)
Parent female	−4.52***	−0.40
	(0.62)	(0.41)
Observations	224,810	256,941
Control group mean	13.45%	7.28%
1st stage Wald	1961	2660

Notes: The table shows how whether the parent enrolls in j affects the likelihood that the other parent also has a degree from field j, and how this differs by parent gender. It is a first stage of sorts for Table C.8. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table C.8. Assortative mating and field inheritance

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent enrolls in j	4.97***	3.65**	3.41***	3.71***	2.60***	1.92***
	(1.31)	(1.29)	(0.98)	(0.85)	(0.77)	(0.56)
× Parent female	−3.44**	−2.03†	−2.72**	−1.85*	−0.95	−0.79
	(1.21)	(1.19)	(0.88)	(0.76)	(0.69)	(0.51)
× Other parent has degree in j	4.69†	5.33*	2.92	2.47	2.84	0.75
	(2.66)	(2.63)	(2.13)	(3.46)	(3.26)	(2.49)
× Parent female × other parent has degree in j	−2.28	−2.97	0.17	−2.77	−2.80	2.03
	(3.68)	(3.64)	(2.98)	(4.66)	(4.39)	(3.37)
Other parent has degree in j	4.91*	4.69*	3.08*	6.13*	5.41*	3.72†
	(1.92)	(1.89)	(1.52)	(2.63)	(2.49)	(1.91)
Parent female × other parent has degree in j	5.53*	4.88†	2.81	4.55	3.47	−0.29
	(2.59)	(2.56)	(2.10)	(3.53)	(3.33)	(2.55)
Parent female	0.65	0.36	0.95*	0.09	0.01	0.21
	(0.57)	(0.56)	(0.41)	(0.34)	(0.30)	(0.22)
Observations	224,810	224,810	224,810	256,941	256,941	256,941
Control group mean	21.66%	20.45%	10.07%	9.71%	7.39%	4.16%
1st stage Wald	966	966	966	1303	1303	1303

Notes: The table shows field inheritance by whether the parent's partner has a degree in the same field and by parent gender. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table C.9. Grandparents' educational level

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent enrolls in j	4.63**	4.15*	4.35**	3.02**	2.60**	1.50†
	(1.77)	(1.71)	(1.34)	(1.12)	(1.01)	(0.78)
× Grandparent high school	−0.76	−0.37	−1.92	0.89	0.77	0.89
	(1.67)	(1.61)	(1.26)	(1.08)	(0.98)	(0.76)
× Grandparent post-secondary	−0.69	−2.29	−4.53†	0.05	1.64	0.21
	(3.43)	(3.37)	(2.65)	(2.40)	(2.26)	(1.66)
× Grandparent tertiary	1.04	0.83	−0.74	1.12	0.48	0.73
	(1.62)	(1.57)	(1.23)	(1.07)	(0.96)	(0.75)
Grandparent high school	0.02	0.31	0.50	−0.54	−0.34	−0.37
	(0.80)	(0.77)	(0.58)	(0.46)	(0.41)	(0.32)
Grandparent post-secondary	0.53	1.82	2.54†	−0.11	−0.20	0.09
	(1.74)	(1.71)	(1.32)	(1.05)	(0.95)	(0.70)
Grandparent tertiary	0.11	1.22	0.36	−0.01	0.31	−0.24
	(0.78)	(0.76)	(0.57)	(0.47)	(0.41)	(0.32)
Observations	224,810	224,810	224,810	256,941	256,941	256,941
Control group mean	21.66%	20.45%	10.07%	9.71%	7.39%	4.16%
1st stage Wald	778	778	778	1065	1065	1065

Notes: Grandparents' educational level is defined as the highest educational level attained by any of an individual's grandparents. The reference group is grandparents with less than upper secondary school education. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table C.10. Field inheritance by parent age at child age 18

	Broad fields			Narrow fields		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent enrolls in *j*	−7.68*	−2.37	−1.71	−2.75	−1.92	−0.89
	(3.67)	(3.58)	(2.77)	(2.14)	(1.76)	(1.42)
× Parent age 41–50	13.18***	6.98*	5.97*	6.43**	5.70***	3.63**
	(3.62)	(3.52)	(2.73)	(2.11)	(1.72)	(1.40)
× Parent age 51–64	12.79***	7.02*	3.92	7.69***	4.59**	2.63†
	(3.63)	(3.55)	(2.74)	(2.14)	(1.76)	(1.42)
× Parent age 65+	−12.33	−28.78	−2.91	−20.80	0.58	−2.24
	(9.00)	(18.13)	(3.37)	(13.36)	(14.84)	(2.00)
Parent age 41–50	−2.99	−1.89	−0.73	−0.84	−0.63	0.03
	(1.95)	(1.87)	(1.42)	(1.05)	(0.84)	(0.66)
Parent age 51–64	−8.54***	−4.75*	−4.57**	−3.16**	−0.66	−1.89**
	(1.97)	(1.88)	(1.43)	(1.07)	(0.86)	(0.67)
Parent age 65+	−10.39†	9.83	−8.63***	5.71	4.79	−4.05***
	(5.59)	(10.36)	(1.68)	(8.98)	(7.33)	(0.90)
Observations	224,810	224,810	224,810	256,941	256,941	256,941
Control group mean	21.66%	20.45%	10.07%	9.71%	7.39%	4.16%
1st stage Wald	977	977	977	1325	1325	1325

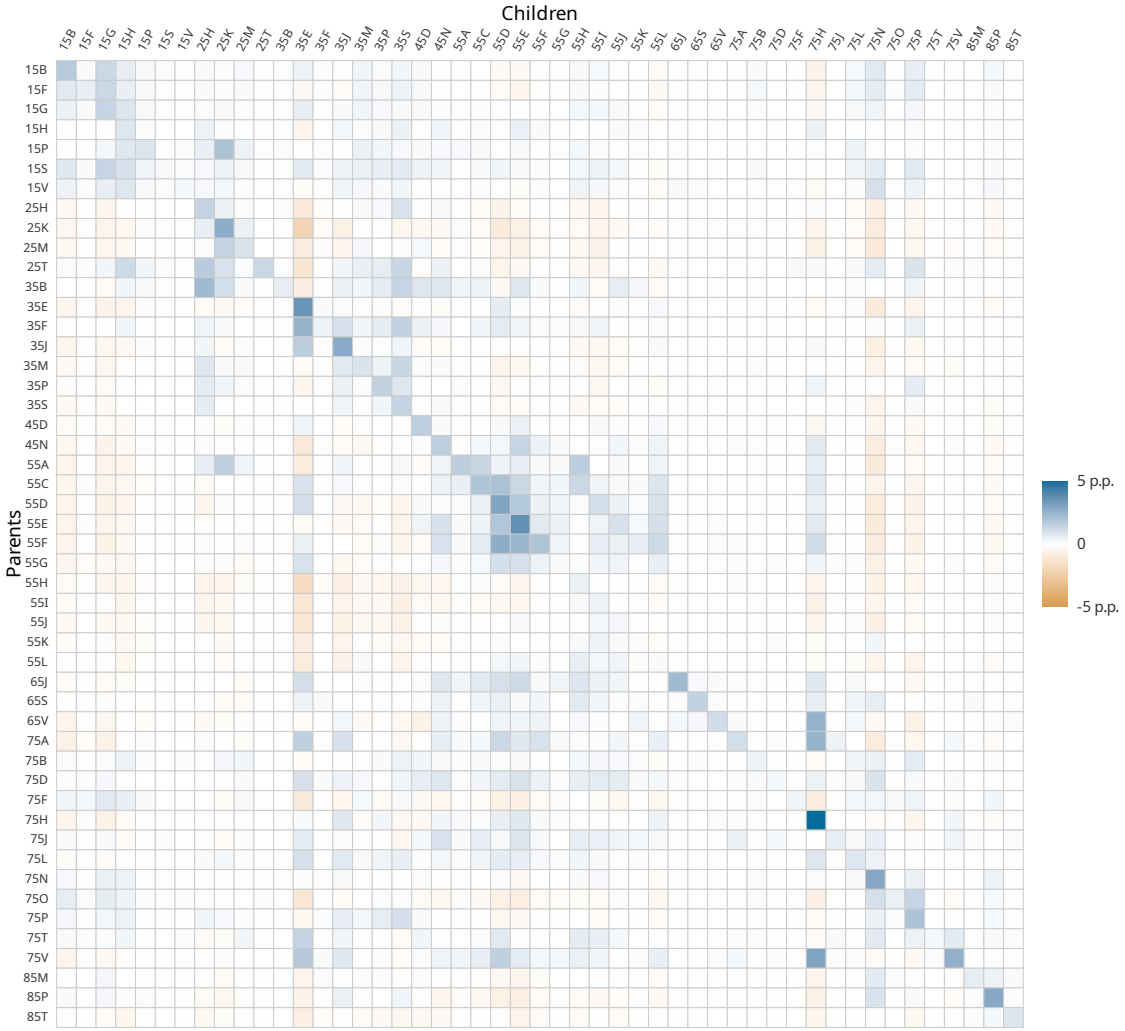
Notes: The estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

D Additional results for narrow fields

This section mirrors the broad-field analysis using narrow SUN field groups. Relative effects are often harder to interpret here, because the finer field definition makes the estimation thinner at each treated margin, several treated margins are excluded, and some control-group means are very small.

Figure D.1. Degrees of children and parents



Notes: Same as Figure 1 but with the narrow definition of fields of study. For a translation of the SunGrp codes, see Table F.2.

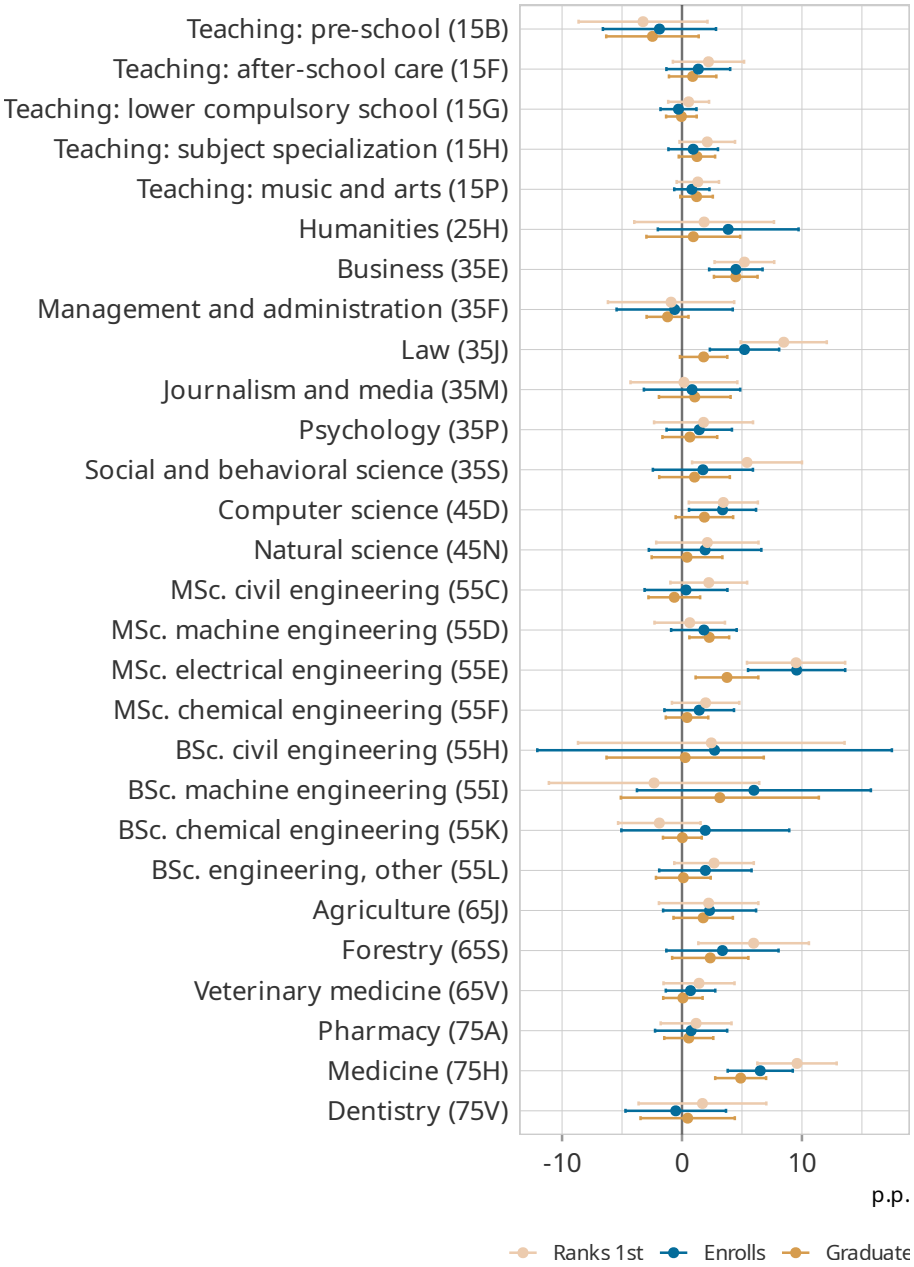
Table D.1. Summary statistics by parent narrow field

	Included in sample	N	Share women	Share enrolled below cutoff	First stage (parent enrolls)
Teaching: pre-school (15B)	Yes	4206	90.7%	32.6%	19.7***
Teaching: after-school care (15F)	Yes	7926	78.9%	19.7%	20.3***
Teaching: lower compulsory school (15G)	Yes	22,209	78.6%	20.8%	36.0***
Teaching: subject specialization (15H)	Yes	15,819	57.6%	22.3%	33.9***
Teaching: music and arts (15P)	Yes	7684	58.9%	14.0%	31.2***
Humanities (25H)	Yes	5190	73.8%	16.5%	14.5***
Media production (25M)	No	207	63.8%	1.4%	3.4
Theology (25T)	No	219	65.3%	20.0%	2.0
Humanities and arts, other (25X)	No	23	60.9%	16.7%	−21.8
Business (35E)	Yes	45,266	47.8%	32.0%	29.3***
Management and administration (35F)	Yes	4739	63.9%	25.1%	18.1***
Law (35J)	Yes	11,694	58.0%	22.1%	24.7***
Journalism and media (35M)	Yes	7901	70.0%	9.6%	31.8***
Psychology (35P)	Yes	5800	66.1%	14.3%	38.2***
Social and behavioral science (35S)	Yes	8639	58.7%	13.6%	25.3***
Social science, other (35X)	No	9377	60.1%	10.3%	11.2***
Computer science (45D)	Yes	8761	41.0%	23.3%	29.6***
Natural science (45N)	Yes	11,266	49.3%	27.7%	15.8***
Natural science, other (45X)	No	241	67.2%	0.0%	0.0
Architecture (55A)	No	6468	53.2%	2.9%	6.6***
MSc. civil engineering (55C)	Yes	5843	37.6%	20.9%	28.3***
MSc. machine engineering (55D)	Yes	15,248	20.3%	26.8%	42.2***
MSc. electrical engineering (55E)	Yes	21,481	16.5%	12.8%	22.1***
MSc. chemical engineering (55F)	Yes	6308	49.0%	22.3%	25.6***
BSc. civil engineering (55H)	Yes	431	23.9%	17.9%	39.6***
BSc. machine engineering (55I)	Yes	714	26.2%	25.2%	18.3*
BSc. electrical engineering (55J)	No	1394	19.3%	30.5%	7.4
BSc. chemical engineering (55K)	Yes	669	85.4%	14.1%	15.5*
BSc. engineering, other (55L)	Yes	896	11.7%	14.1%	32.9***
Technology and manufacturing, other (55X)	No	53	13.2%	0.0%	
Agriculture (65J)	Yes	3543	51.8%	32.8%	23.7***
Forestry (65S)	Yes	2112	17.2%	36.3%	36.5***
Veterinary medicine (65V)	Yes	3401	67.5%	16.0%	54.1***
Agriculture, other (65X)	No	168	10.7%	2.0%	59.9**
Pharmacy (75A)	Yes	3337	73.9%	22.9%	17.1***
Child care (75F)	No	456	56.8%	5.2%	19.1†
Medicine (75H)	Yes	20,696	44.3%	42.4%	31.9***
Pharmacy (dispenser) (75J)	No	1784	94.6%	15.0%	3.6
Social care (75O)	No	5765	78.2%	39.8%	10.5***
Social work (75P)	No	16,125	79.1%	1.2%	0.8
Dentistry (75V)	Yes	5167	50.1%	36.5%	9.9**
Care, other (75X)	No	4418	80.9%	22.8%	26.3***
Transport services (85T)	No	49	38.8%	0.0%	
Transport service, other (85X)	No	7079	78.9%	10.6%	14.6***
Other (95Z)	No	144	36.1%	40.8%	8.6

Notes: This table corresponds to Table 2, but the statistics are grouped by narrow fields. Fields marked "No" remain in the data as counterfactual margins but are excluded as treated margins because of small samples, weak first stages, or because they are residual catch-all groups that are hard to interpret.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Figure D.2. Inheritance of narrow fields



Notes: The figure corresponds to Figure 5 but for narrow fields. The point estimates are reported in Table D.2. The regression uses the same specification as the main analysis in Table 3.

Table D.2. Field heterogeneity narrow fields

Field	Ranks 1st			Enrolls			Graduates		
Teaching: pre-school (15B)	−3.25	(2.74)	−93%	−1.88	(2.41)	−72%	−2.46	(1.97)	−135%
Teaching: after-school care (15F)	2.21	(1.51)	222%	1.36	(1.36)	164%	0.89	(1.01)	171%
Teaching: lower compulsory school (15G)	0.55	(0.87)	16%	−0.29	(0.77)	−11%	−0.05	(0.65)	−2%
Teaching: subject specialization (15H)	$2.11^{\dagger}$	(1.18)	47%	0.93	(1.05)	27%	1.25	(0.77)	65%
Teaching: music and arts (15P)	1.32	(0.90)	189%	0.82	(0.75)	220%	$1.22^{\dagger}$	(0.69)	370%
Humanities (25H)	1.84	(2.97)	32%	3.85	(2.99)	69%	0.94	(2.00)	39%
Business (35E)	5.20^{***}	(1.27)	25%	4.49^{***}	(1.14)	30%	4.48^{***}	(0.93)	46%
Management and administration (35F)	−0.91	(2.69)	−12%	−0.61	(2.47)	−10%	−1.20	(0.89)	−162%
Law (35J)	8.48^{***}	(1.83)	72%	5.21^{***}	(1.47)	79%	$1.80^{\dagger}$	(1.01)	56%
Journalism and media (35M)	0.16	(2.27)	3%	0.84	(2.05)	18%	1.06	(1.52)	46%
Psychology (35P)	1.80	(2.10)	19%	1.44	(1.39)	41%	0.65	(1.17)	26%
Social and behavioral science (35S)	5.42^{*}	(2.34)	58%	1.74	(2.13)	22%	1.04	(1.50)	28%
Computer science (45D)	3.45^{*}	(1.47)	69%	3.38^{*}	(1.43)	70%	1.87	(1.22)	50%
Natural science (45N)	2.11	(2.18)	32%	1.93	(2.39)	24%	0.42	(1.50)	14%
MSc. civil engineering (55C)	2.23	(1.63)	55%	0.33	(1.76)	6%	−0.64	(1.10)	−27%
MSc. machine engineering (55D)	0.64	(1.50)	4%	1.83	(1.39)	14%	2.27^{**}	(0.85)	48%
MSc. electrical engineering (55E)	9.51^{***}	(2.09)	72%	9.56^{***}	(2.07)	75%	3.75^{**}	(1.33)	75%
MSc. chemical engineering (55F)	1.97	(1.43)	45%	1.44	(1.48)	30%	0.42	(0.90)	23%
BSc. civil engineering (55H)	2.44	(5.67)	79%	2.72	(7.54)	53%	0.26	(3.34)	12%
BSc. machine engineering (55I)	−2.33	(4.47)	−77%	6.00	(4.98)	270%	3.16	(4.21)	211%
BSc. chemical engineering (55K)	−1.89	(1.75)	−391%	1.94	(3.57)	1005%	0.03	(0.82)	N/A
BSc. engineering, other (55L)	2.67	(1.69)	1060%	1.95	(1.96)	258%	0.11	(1.16)	29%
Agriculture (65J)	2.22	(2.11)	56%	2.30	(1.98)	73%	1.77	(1.26)	142%
Forestry (65S)	5.97^{*}	(2.35)	231%	3.37	(2.39)	131%	2.36	(1.62)	202%
Veterinary medicine (65V)	1.42	(1.51)	49%	0.71	(1.05)	60%	0.08	(0.84)	8%
Pharmacy (75A)	1.18	(1.51)	152%	0.76	(1.53)	74%	0.57	(1.04)	219%
Medicine (75H)	9.59^{***}	(1.69)	59%	6.52^{***}	(1.38)	65%	4.89^{***}	(1.08)	75%
Dentistry (75V)	1.71	(2.72)	46%	−0.52	(2.14)	−22%	0.47	(2.01)	26%
Aggregate	4.00^{***}	(0.75)	40%	3.23^{***}	(0.68)	43%	2.24^{***}	(0.51)	53%

Notes: The table reports the estimates from Figure D.2. The third column in each outcome group reports the relative effect compared with the control-group mean. These relative effects can be unstable when the control-group mean is very small.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table D.3. Narrow field associations and causal effects

Field	Causal effect			OLS association		
Teaching: pre-school (15B)	−3.22	(2.38)	−177%	1.70***	(0.05)	293%
Teaching: after-school care (15F)	0.89	(1.21)	171%	0.53***	(0.06)	328%
Teaching: lower compulsory school (15G)	−0.09	(0.74)	−4%	1.36***	(0.06)	162%
Teaching: subject specialization (15H)	1.75	(1.09)	91%	0.78***	(0.06)	82%
Teaching: music and arts (15P)	1.55†	(0.92)	472%	0.82***	(0.07)	384%
Humanities (25H)	3.14	(7.04)	130%	1.39***	(0.09)	152%
Business (35E)	6.96***	(1.46)	72%	3.55***	(0.09)	98%
Management and administration (35F)	−2.04	(1.46)	−275%	0.41***	(0.07)	108%
Law (35J)	2.85†	(1.61)	89%	2.80***	(0.13)	213%
Journalism and media (35M)	1.21	(1.69)	52%	0.86***	(0.14)	110%
Psychology (35P)	1.13	(2.15)	44%	1.44***	(0.13)	162%
Social and behavioral science (35S)	2.63	(4.19)	70%	1.43***	(0.12)	71%
Computer science (45D)	2.96	(2.00)	80%	1.56***	(0.10)	116%
Natural science (45N)	0.69	(2.58)	23%	1.57***	(0.09)	131%
MSc. civil engineering (55C)	−0.73	(1.30)	−31%	1.89***	(0.14)	329%
MSc. machine engineering (55D)	3.01**	(1.14)	64%	3.00***	(0.13)	219%
MSc. electrical engineering (55E)	2.84**	(1.00)	57%	3.67***	(0.13)	265%
MSc. chemical engineering (55F)	0.52	(1.08)	28%	1.93***	(0.15)	452%
BSc. civil engineering (55H)	0.17	(4.62)	8%	0.47***	(0.12)	52%
BSc. machine engineering (55I)	5.33	(7.32)	356%	0.41***	(0.09)	47%
BSc. chemical engineering (55K)	0.06	(0.99)	N/A	0.14†	(0.07)	76%
BSc. engineering, other (55L)	0.21	(2.05)	56%	0.16	(0.17)	26%
Agriculture (65J)	2.31	(1.62)	186%	2.26***	(0.19)	2407%
Forestry (65S)	2.74	(1.86)	235%	1.46***	(0.19)	2199%
Veterinary medicine (65V)	0.06	(0.88)	7%	1.11***	(0.27)	1412%
Pharmacy (75A)	0.70	(1.28)	273%	1.07***	(0.21)	830%
Medicine (75H)	5.20***	(1.15)	80%	6.07***	(0.15)	577%
Dentistry (75V)	0.77	(2.94)	42%	2.58***	(0.20)	1433%
Aggregate	2.96***	(0.67)	70%	1.85***	(0.02)	307%

Notes: The "OLS association" column reports the diagonal of Figure D.1: the OLS coefficient from regressing an indicator for the child holding a degree in the parent's narrow field on an indicator for the parent holding that degree, estimated on degree-holding parents. The "Causal effect" column reports the corresponding IV estimate of parental degree completion on child degree completion from the RD design. In both columns, absolute effects are in percentage points and relative effects express the absolute effect as a percentage of the respective baseline rate (applicants below the cutoff for RD and parents with degrees in other fields for OLS). The comparison is informative but not mechanically one-to-one because the association and estimated effect columns use different denominators.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

E Analysis of additional treatment margins

Instead of collapsing alternatives by field of study and looking at treatment margins where applicants are either admitted into one field or deferred to another, we can perform the same exercise but for institutions.[19] This is a useful way to gain an additional measure against which we can benchmark the main results. It is also useful for understanding to what extent the estimated effects are driven by certain (perhaps elite) institutions. Table E.1 reports the results of this exercise, where the outcome variables take the value 1 if the child follows to the same institution, regardless of what field of study they choose.

When a parent enrolls in a specific institution, the child becomes about 4.4 percentage points, or roughly three quarters, more likely to graduate from that institution. While the effect is somewhat larger than the results in Table 3, the difference is not as stark as in Altmejd et al. (2021).

Table E.1. Inheritance of institutions

	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	17.29%	19.10%	23.90%
	3.42^{***}	3.24^{***}	1.39^{***}
	(0.27)	(0.26)	(0.16)
Parent enrolls in j	54.79%	60.52%	75.73%
	10.82^{***}	10.26^{***}	4.41^{***}
	(0.84)	(0.81)	(0.51)
Parent receives degree in j	72.05%	79.58%	99.58%
	14.23^{***}	13.49^{***}	5.80^{***}
	(1.12)	(1.06)	(0.67)
Observations	345,258	345,258	345,258
Control group mean	19.76%	16.96%	5.82%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	8084	8084	8084
1st stage Wald (degree)	4671	4671	4671

Notes: Instead of collapsing consecutive options by field of study, the sample includes applications collapsed by institution. A child is thus classified as following their parent only if they pick the same institution as their parent, irrespective of what program they chose. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

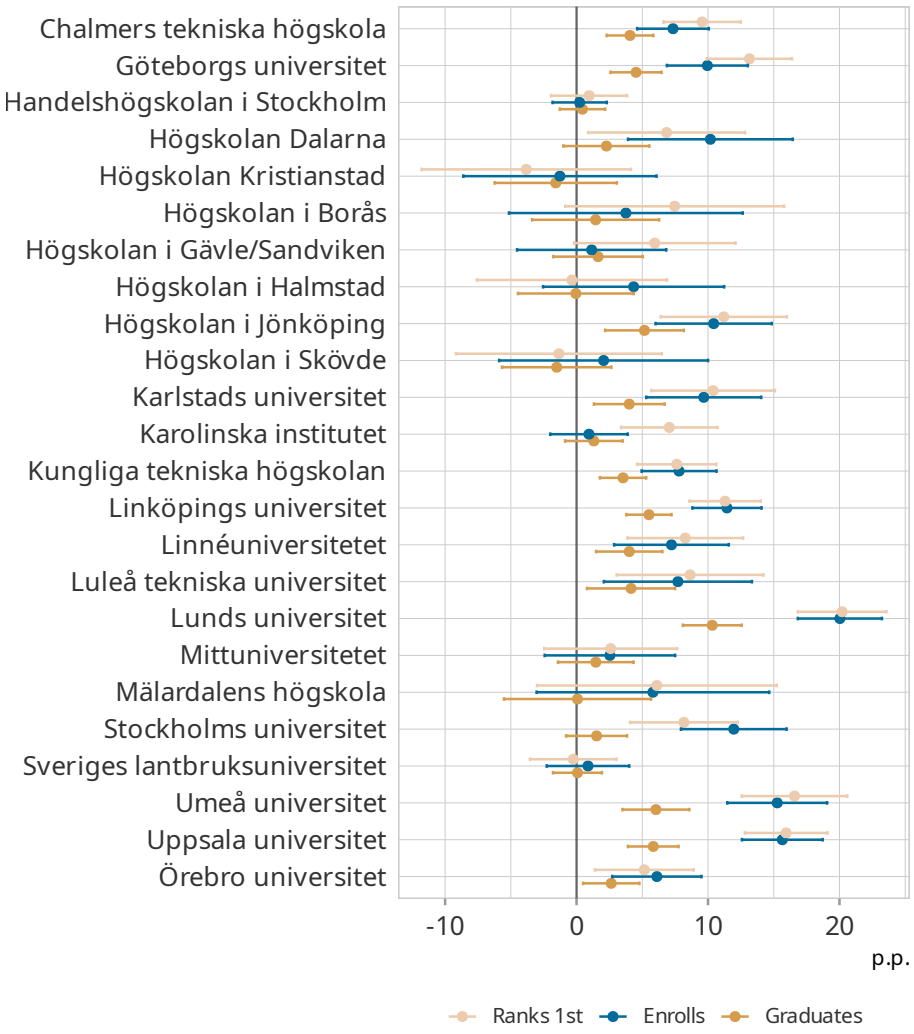
† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Figure E.1 presents separate coefficients for each institution. Again, we see very few negative effects, but quite a bit of heterogeneity. The largest and most precise estimates are for big universities that offer a broad range of alternatives and are located in towns with no other higher education institutions (e.g., Lund, Uppsala, Umeå). The two most prestigious schools—probably the only ones that could be referred to as "elite"—the Stockholm School of Economics (Handelshögskolan i Stockholm) and the Karolinska Institute, both exhibit tiny effects that are not significant. This is despite their specializing in two of the most often inherited fields: business and medicine. A possible reason for this is that the high admission thresholds prevent most children from following their parents there. This is in contrast

19. Many institutions have changed their names, merged, or reorganized during the period. I only include institutions that have existed during at least some part of the parent application period (1977–1992) and classify rebranded institutions with the same identifier. For example, Linnéuniversitet is a merger of Kalmar and Växjö universities. A child who goes to Linnéuniversitet is classified as following their parent no matter which of the two schools that parent applied to.

to the findings by Barrios-Fernández et al. (2024), however, who show that access to elite universities is inherited in Chile.

Figure E.1. Inheritance of institutions



Notes: The regression is run on a sample constructed by collapsing consecutive alternatives by institution rather than field. It uses the same specification as the main analysis in Table 3 but with next-best fixed effects at the institution level.

As noted above, inheriting institutional preferences is likely explained by how institutions are located in different cities. Since a significant share of parents who move to a new city for their university studies stay there, admission also affects what city their children live in. Table E.2 shows the results of exploiting the variation in institution location specifically. Here, alternatives are grouped by commuting zone (2018 local labor market). This means that consecutively ranked applications to schools in the Stockholm-Uppsala region are collapsed, for example. The results are larger than for institutions, but also with higher baselines, yielding relative effects between roughly two thirds and four fifths and showing how important location is for university choice.

Table E.2. Inheritance of locations

	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	18.84%	20.08%	22.89%
	4.58***	4.59***	2.01***
	(0.30)	(0.30)	(0.21)
Parent enrolls in j	64.29%	68.53%	78.13%
	15.65***	15.67***	6.88***
	(1.01)	(0.99)	(0.71)
Parent receives degree in j	79.17%	84.39%	96.22%
	19.27***	19.30***	8.47***
	(1.25)	(1.23)	(0.87)
Observations	303,548	303,548	303,548
Control group mean	24.34%	22.86%	8.8%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	6370	6370	6370
1st stage Wald (degree)	4071	4071	4071

Notes: Instead of collapsing consecutive options by field of study, the sample includes applications collapsed by local labor market. A child is thus classified as following their parent as long as they choose a program at an institution in the same local labor market (commuting zone) as their parent, irrespective of what program and institution it is. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Next, I group consecutive alternatives by their field-institution combination. Now, only consecutive options to the same field and institution are collapsed. Table E.3 reports these aggregate results. Not surprisingly, baseline shares are considerably smaller, but so are the absolute effects. In the left panel, parental enrollment in a field-institution combination increases the child's graduation probability by 1.71 percentage points. The right panel reports the likelihood that a child follows to the same field when the parent is on the margin between two different fields in the same institution. This is the main effect but estimated on a subsample where institution does not change. The effects remain sizeable for ranking and enrollment, but the graduation effect is small and imprecisely estimated. These results suggest that the paper's main estimates are not driven solely by intergenerational spillovers of institutions or locations.

Finally, Table E.5 reports results for the extensive margin. Here, all the parents' preferences are collapsed and we study enrolling in any university program versus not. Consequently, outcome dummies are switched on when a child applies to, enrolls in, or graduates from any program. The estimates show little evidence of effects on child application or graduation. There is some evidence of a positive enrollment effect, but it is modest relative to the high baseline, so parental enrollment does not appear to materially increase overall college-going in this sample. Like previous results, these are local average treatment effects for applicants on the margin between going to university or not, and complying with treatment. While still significant, and with fairly strong Wald statistics reported in Table E.5, the first stages in Table E.4 are much weaker. The compliers are thus likely quite different from the full population.

Table E.3. Inheritance of field-institutions

	Field-institution			Field (holding institution constant)		
	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	1.15***	1.10***	0.48***	1.41***	1.00**	0.21
	(0.11)	(0.11)	(0.06)	(0.40)	(0.38)	(0.21)
Parent enrolls in j	4.06***	3.89***	1.71***	4.32***	3.07**	0.64
	(0.40)	(0.38)	(0.23)	(1.24)	(1.15)	(0.64)
Parent receives degree in j	5.87***	5.62***	2.47***	6.99***	4.97**	1.03
	(0.58)	(0.55)	(0.33)	(2.01)	(1.86)	(1.04)
Observations	1,050,682	1,050,682	1,050,682	77,082	77,082	77,082
Control group mean	6.51%	5.45%	1.85%	9.55%	7.92%	2.53%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	15,331	15,331	15,331	1968	1968	1968
1st stage Wald (degree)	7365	7365	7365	796	796	796

Notes: Instead of collapsing consecutive options by field of study, the sample includes applications collapsed by institution-field combinations. The right panel is then further limited to only include applicants where their preferred institution-field combination (j) is at the same institution as their next-best (k). A child is classified as following their parent only if they pick the same institution and field as their parent. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table E.4. Extensive margin first stage

	Parent admitted to j	Parent enrolls in j	Parent receives degree in j
Parent above cutoff to j	70.91***	6.38***	6.01***
	(0.18)	(0.23)	(0.29)
Observations	394,482	394,482	394,482
Control group mean	0%	72.49%	53.05%

Notes: The table reports first stage estimates for the extensive margin analysis in Table E.5.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

Table E.5. Extensive margin inheritance

	Ranks 1st	Enrolls	Graduates
Parent above cutoff to j	0.46%	0.88%	0.04%
	$0.35^{\dagger}$	0.63^{**}	0.02
	(0.21)	(0.22)	(0.24)
Parent enrolls in j	7.26%	13.76%	0.59%
	$5.56^{\dagger}$	9.83^{**}	0.31
	(3.28)	(3.47)	(3.81)
Parent receives degree in j	7.70%	14.60%	0.62%
	$5.90^{\dagger}$	10.43^{**}	0.33
	(3.48)	(3.69)	(4.04)
Observations	800,803	800,803	800,803
Control group mean	76.56%	71.43%	52.91%
1st stage Wald (enrolls)	753	753	753
1st stage Wald (degree)	429	429	429

Notes: This table reports results for the extensive margin. Here, all the parents' preference rankings are collapsed and we study enrolling in any program versus not enrolling at all. Consequently, outcome dummies are switched on when a child applies to, enrolls in, or graduates from any program. Otherwise, the estimation follows the same approach as in Table 3. Compared to the main analysis, first stages for this specification are much weaker.

† $p \leq 0.1$, * $p \leq 0.05$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, *** $p \leq 0.001$.

F Codebook

Table F.1. Broad field descriptions

Broad field	Description
Teaching	Teaching programs for all ages. Programs are often specialized for a certain age group or subject. Also includes practical teaching programs like sports or arts teaching.
Humanities	Cultural studies, Theology, Media.
Business	Business, administration, accounting, finance.
Law	Programs that yield law degrees.
Social science	Political science, journalism, sociology, psychology, behavioral science, library science
Natural science	Mathematics, biology, chemistry, physics, environmental science, statistics
Technology	Both shorter and longer engineering programs, typically taught at technical universities. Also includes computer science, architecture and urban planning.
Agriculture	Farming, veterinary studies, forestry, etc.
Medicine	Programs that yield medical degrees.
Health	Dentistry, pharmacy, counselling, social work, physical therapy, nursing (although nursing was not a university program in the parent generation)
Services	Tourism, recreation, sports

Table F.2. Narrow field codes, descriptions, and corresponding broad fields

Code	Description	Broad field
15B	Teaching: pre-school	Teaching
15F	Teaching: after-school care	Teaching
15G	Teaching: lower compulsory school	Teaching
15H	Teaching: subject specialization	Teaching
15P	Teaching: music and arts	Teaching
15S	Teaching: special needs	Teaching
15V	Teaching: vocational	Teaching
15X	Teaching: other	Teaching
25H	Humanities	Humanities
25K	Arts and media	Humanities
25M	Media production	Humanities
25T	Theology	Humanities
25X	Humanities and arts, other	Humanities
35B	Library science	Social science
35E	Business	Social science
35E	Business	Business
35F	Management and administration	Business
35J	Law	Law
35M	Journalism and media	Social science
35P	Psychology	Social science
35S	Social and behavioral science	Social science
35X	Social science, other	Social science
35X	Social science, other	Business
35X	Social science, other	Law
45D	Computer science	Technology
45N	Natural science	Natural science
45N	Natural science	Technology
45X	Natural science, other	Natural science
45X	Natural science, other	Technology
55A	Architecture	Technology
55C	MSc. civil engineering	Technology
55D	MSc. machine engineering	Technology
55E	MSc. electrical engineering	Technology
55F	MSc. chemical engineering	Technology
55G	MSc. engineering, other	Technology
55H	BSc. civil engineering	Technology
55I	BSc. machine engineering	Technology
55J	BSc. electrical engineering	Technology
55K	BSc. chemical engineering	Technology
55L	BSc. engineering, other	Technology
55X	Technology and manufacturing, other	Technology
65J	Agriculture	Agriculture
65S	Forestry	Agriculture
65V	Veterinary medicine	Agriculture
65X	Agriculture, other	Agriculture
75A	Pharmacy	Health
75B	Occupational therapy	Health
75D	Biomedical analyst	Health
75F	Child care	Health
75H	Medicine	Medicine
75J	Pharmacy (dispenser)	Health
75L	Physiotherapy	Health
75N	Nursing	Health
75O	Social care	Health
75P	Social work	Health
75T	Dental hygiene	Health
75V	Dentistry	Health
75X	Care, other	Health
75X	Care, other	Medicine
85M	Officer	Services
85P	Policing	Services
85T	Transport services	Services
85X	Transport service, other	Services
95Z	Other	Other
99Z	Unknown	Other

Notes: This table shows the mapping between broad and narrow fields. Narrow fields are SCB SUN2000Grp codes, defined jointly by a 4-digit SUN2000Inr field code and a 3-digit SUN2000Niva level code. Broad fields group only field codes. Because one classification uses both field and level while the other uses field only, some narrow fields can map to multiple broad fields in the underlying codebook. Take Medicine. Medical programs are 5-year programs, meaning that a medicine-coded program (SUN2000Inr = 721a-k) is only given the SUN2000Grp code 75H if SUN2000Niva is also 550 and above, while the broad field "Medicine" includes all education coded with the right SUN2000Inr codes.